

THE ROLE OF EQUITY AND DIVERSITY IN EARLY CHILDHOOD EDUCATIO



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The Role of Equity and Diversity in Early Childhood Education

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Looking at Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Define diversity, equity, and inclusion.
- Examine the importance of diversity.
- Distinguish the difference between equity and equality.
- Explain what inclusion means.
- Discuss some ways programs should be inclusive.

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1.1: Diversity

Diversity

Let's begin by defining diversity and exploring its significance to working with children. The concept of diversity means understanding that each individual is unique, and recognizing our individual differences. These can be along the dimensions of race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, socio-economic status, age, physical abilities, religious beliefs, political beliefs, or other ideologies. It is the exploration of these differences in a safe, positive, and nurturing environment. It is about understanding each other and moving beyond simple tolerance to embracing and celebrating the rich dimensions of diversity contained within each individual.



Figure 1.1: Diversity in early childhood education. ^[3]

Diversity is a reality created by individuals and groups from a broad spectrum of demographic and philosophical differences. It is extremely important to support and protect diversity, to value individuals and groups without prejudice, and foster a climate where equity and mutual respect are intrinsic.

According to Queensborough Community College, “‘Diversity’ means more than just acknowledging and/or tolerating difference. Diversity is a set of conscious practices that involve:

- Understanding and appreciating interdependence of humanity, cultures, and the natural environment.
- Practicing mutual respect for qualities and experiences that are different from our own.
- Understanding that diversity includes not only ways of being but also ways of knowing;
- Recognizing that personal, cultural and institutionalized discrimination creates and sustains privileges for some while creating and sustaining disadvantages for others;
- Building alliances across differences so that we can work together to eradicate all forms of discrimination.

Diversity includes, therefore, knowing how to relate to those qualities and conditions that are different from our own and outside the groups to which we belong, yet are present in other individuals and groups. These include but are not limited to age, ethnicity, class, gender, physical abilities/qualities, race, sexual orientation, as well as religious status, gender expression, educational background, geographical location, income, marital status, parental status, and work experiences. Finally, we acknowledge that categories of difference are not always fixed but also can be fluid, we respect individual rights to self-identification, and we recognize that no one culture is intrinsically superior to another”. ^[4]

Cultural and Linguistic Diversity in the U.S. and California

There is a rich array of ethnic and social groups found in many early childhood programs in California. Much of this cultural diversity is due to high levels of immigration. Foreign-born persons represented 12 percent (32.5 million) of the U.S. population in 2002, with almost 50 percent of that group coming from Latin America, 25 percent from Asia, and 20 percent from Europe (Schmidley 2003). In 2010, of the more than 2.5 million children under the age of five living in California, about half of these

children were Latino (U.S. Census Bureau 2010). It is important to note that Latinos may be of any race, according to the U.S. Census Bureau. White non-Latino children make up 30 percent of children under five in California, Asian-Pacific Islanders make up 10 percent, Black or African Americans make up 6 percent, and the remaining 4 percent represent a wide range of ethnic groups (Whitebook, Kipnis, and Bellm 2008). ^[5]

Significance of Diversity

A growing body of research shows that diversity in schools and communities can be a powerful lever leading to positive outcomes in school and in life. Racial and socioeconomic diversity benefits communities, schools, and children from all backgrounds. Today's students need to be prepared to succeed with a more diverse and more global workforce than ever before. Research has shown that more diverse organizations make better decisions with better results. The effects of socioeconomic diversity can be especially powerful for students from low-income families, who, historically, often have not had equal access to the resources they need to succeed. ^[6]



Figure 1.2: Diversity in schools, including ECE, is beneficial. ^[7]

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1.2: Equity

In education, the term equity refers to the principle of fairness . While it is often used interchangeably with the related principle of equality , equity encompasses a wide variety of educational models, programs, and strategies that may be considered fair, but not necessarily equal. ^[8] In other words, equity means making sure every student has the support they need to be successful.

Equity in education “requires putting systems in place to ensure that every child has an equal chance for success. That requires understanding the unique challenges and barriers faced by individual students or by populations of students and providing additional supports to help them overcome those barriers. While this in itself may not ensure equal outcomes , we all should strive to ensure that every child has equal opportunity for success.” ^[9] Unlike equity, equality ignores the fact that different people begin with different resources and barriers, and therefore will need more or less support as a result. ^[10]

Figure 1.3 is a simplified visual of difference between equality (giving everyone the same thing) and equity (giving each person what they need).

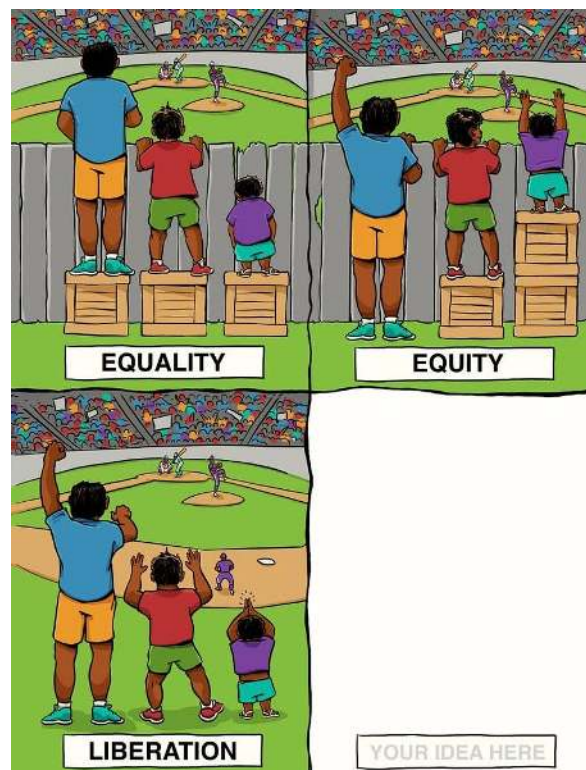


Figure 1.3: A simplified visual of equality versus equity. ^[11]

Other images have been created that show that equity isn't quite that simple and often what is creating the inequity is not characteristics of the person (such as height as shown in the image), but in the system. Systemic oppression and unearned privilege are addressed in later chapters of the book

Why Does Educational Equity Matter?

When we think of a fair and just society one of the defining characteristics is likely to be that all individuals have equal opportunity to realize their potential, irrespective of the circumstances into which they are born. Education plays a critical role in determining whether or not individuals are given this opportunity. There are a range of reasons why good educational outcomes matter, from the individual; better health and longer life, to the societal; greater social cohesion, inclusion and trust; to the economic, productivity, economic growth, innovation, social wealth and reduced welfare costs. For a society or nation committed to 'creating a fair and egalitarian place in which opportunities exist for all', education is a key lever or vehicle through which this can occur. ^[12]



Figure 1.4: Making sure all children have equal opportunities is critical. ^[13]

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1.3: Inclusion

When we talk about inclusive early childhood education, we are talking about programs that are designed for children and families from a wide range of backgrounds. A program can serve diverse families, but not be truly inclusive; you can have families from different backgrounds in your program, but do they feel welcome? Are you forcing them to adapt to a program that isn't designed for them or that doesn't take into consideration their social, cultural, and/or racial contexts? Designing an inclusive program translates to everything from physical space to how you interact with children and families. ^[14]

Inclusion as it Relates to Children with Disabilities

Inclusion embodies the values, policies, and practices that support the right of every child and their family, regardless of ability, to participate in a broad range of activities and contexts as full members of families, communities, and society. The desired results of inclusive experiences for children with and without disabilities and their families include a sense of belonging and membership, positive social relationships and friendships, and development and learning to reach their full potential. The defining features of inclusion that can be used to identify high quality early childhood programs and services are:

- Access - providing access to a wide range of learning opportunities, activities, settings, and environments
- Participation - even if environments and programs are designed to facilitate access, some children will need additional individualized accommodations and supports to participate fully in play and learning activities with peers and adults.
- Supports - an infrastructure of systems-level supports must be afforded to those providing inclusive services to children and families. ^[15]



Figure 1.5: All children need to be able to fully participate in the early childhood education environment. ^[16]

Children with disabilities and their families continue to face significant barriers to accessing inclusive high-quality early childhood programs and too many preschool children with disabilities are only offered the option of receiving special education services in settings separate from their peers without disabilities. ^[17]

Think About It...

Describe your understanding of how diversity, equity, and inclusion are related.

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1.4: Summary

Early childhood programs serve a diverse array of children and families. Recognizing the value of this diversity and creating relationships with families that provide the context of their culture, will allow early childhood education programs to be inclusive in a variety of different ways and provide educational equity for the children for whom they provide care and education.

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SECTION OVERVIEW

1.5: The Importance of Culture

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Discuss what culture is and how it has been defined or described
- Describe how culture is passed
- Identify myths about culture
- Relate how culture affects development
- Explain the importance of being responsive to children and families' culture

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: The Importance of Culture

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Discuss what culture is and how it has been defined or described
- Describe how culture is passed
- Identify myths about culture
- Relate how culture affects development
- Explain the importance of being responsive to children and families' culture

[2.1: Introduction](#)

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2.1: Introduction

Culture is a broad concept that refers to the customs, values, beliefs, and practices of a group of people. It incorporates family roles, rituals, communication styles, emotional expression, social interactions, and learned behavior. Culture also refers to a shared way of life that includes social norms, rules, beliefs, and values that are transmitted across generations (Hill, McBride-Murry, and Anderson 2005, 23). Although cultural groups often share ethnic and linguistic backgrounds, these are not what define culture. Culture has been described as arising from “a dynamic system of social values, cognitive codes, of behavioral standards, worldviews, and beliefs used to give order and meaning to our lives” (Gay 2000, 8).

Culture infuses and is reflected in routines of daily living. Culture is a primary source of beliefs, attitudes, language, and personal efficacy (belief that one has control over and is responsible for one’s life), sense of time (whether time is thought of in large chunks such as hours and days rather than precisely in terms of minutes and seconds), and perceptions of personal space. Culture is the source of the symbols used to capture aspects of life such as important life transitions, relationships, status and power, achievement, group identity, and the meaning of life and death. Culture conveys a set of beliefs about how social relationships should be ordered and how the world operates. ^[18]

A variety of definitions of culture are provided in the table below. The purpose of providing these definitions is to invite us to review and discuss the various definitions of the term as a framework for further discussions. ^[19]

Table 2.1: Definitions of Culture ^[20]

Culture is...
• The organized and common practices of particular communities. • A shared organization of ideas that includes the intellectual, moral, and aesthetic standards prevalent in a community and the meaning of communicative actions. • The complex processes of human social interaction and symbolic communication. • A set of activities by which different groups produce collective memories, knowledge, social relationships, and values within historically controlled relations of power. • An instrument people use as they struggle to survive in a social group. • A framework that guides and bounds life practices. • All that is done by people. • The ways and manners people use to see, perceive, represent, interpret, and assign value and meaning to the reality they live or experience. • The complex whole that includes knowledge, beliefs, art, morals, customs, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society. • Shared understanding, as well as the public customs and artifacts that embody these understandings. • Patterns, explicit and implicit, of and for behavior acquired and transmitted by symbols, constituting the distinctive achievement of human groups, including their embodiments in artifacts. • Not so much a matter of inert system in which people operate, but rather a historical construction by people that is always changing.

Culture is complex and is something we are exposed to from the day we are born. It is a process detailed in the following deep structures:

1. Culture is a set of rules for behavior . Culture cannot be “seen” because the rules are invisible; one can see only the products of culture: the behaviors produced by the rules. Nevertheless, cultural rules do not cause behavior; they influence people to behave similarly, in ways that help them to understand each other. It is by understanding a culture’s rules that one knows how to greet a person younger than oneself, older than oneself, a friend, or a stranger. Cultural rules help people to know how to hold a baby. Cultural rules shape food preferences and celebrations—determine whether the sun or the moon is celebrated; whether to wear a dress or pants, or nothing at all. These rules give meaning to all the events and experiences of life. The essence of culture is not these behaviors themselves, but the rules that produce the behaviors.
2. Culture is characteristic of groups. The rules of a culture are shared by the group, not invented by the individual. The rules of the group, which are passed on from one generation to the next, form the core of the culture. Although one must remember that in addition to group cultural differences, there are individual differences. Each person develops a unique personality as a result

of his or her personal history and, at the same time, develops in a cultural context with some behavioral characteristics that are shared by other members of the group.



Figure 2.2: Culture is not seen, but you can see the behaviors that result from acculturation. ^[21]

3. Culture is learned. No one is born acculturated; rather, each person is born with a biological capacity to learn. What each person learns depends upon the cultural rules of the people who raised them. Some rules are taught with words: “hold your fork in your right hand, and your knife in your left.” Other rules are demonstrated by actions—when to smile, how close to stand when talking to someone, and so on. Because culture is learned, it is a mistake to assume a person’s culture by the way she or he looks. Someone may be racially black and culturally Irish. A person can also become bicultural or multicultural by learning the rules of cultures other than his or her own primary group.
4. Individuals are embedded, to different degrees, within a culture. Culture is learned and as children are acculturated, they usually learn the core rules of their culture, yet they may not always learn each cultural rule equally well. Some families are more bound to tradition, others less so. Further, even though families and individuals learn the cultural rules, they may not always behave according to what they have learned—some people are conformists; others are nonconformists. Consequently, the behavior of members of a cultural group will vary, depending on how deeply embedded their experiences are within the core of a culture. Thinking about behavioral variations in this way helps those who work with individual families to understand why those from a similar culture do not share all culturally based behaviors.
5. Cultural groups borrow and share rules. Each cultural group has its own set of core behavioral rules and is therefore unique; yet some of the rules of Culture A may be the same as the rules of Culture B. This happens because cultural rules evolve and change over time, and sometimes when two groups have extensive contact with one another, they influence each other in some areas. Thus, two groups of people may speak the same language, yet have different rules about roles for women. Understanding of this concept helps to avoid confusion when a person from another culture is so much like the teacher in some ways, yet so different in other ways.
6. Members of a cultural group may be proficient at cultural behavior but unable to describe the rules. Acculturation is a natural process; as people become acculturated, they are not conscious that their ideas and behavior are being shaped by a unique set of rules. Just as a four-year-old who is proficient with language cannot diagram a sentence or explain the rules of grammar if asked to do so, so also people may become thoroughly proficient with cultural behavior without consciously knowing that they behave according to rules. In the same way, understanding acculturation explains why one cannot walk up to a person and ask him or her to explain their culture.

Cultivating openness about culture and development promotes a curiosity for the early childhood educator that helps with curtailing the two common assumptions that exist in society today. The first assumption is that there is one set of “best practices” and one set

of universal developmental goals for all children and families. By avoiding this static view and looking instead at culture as a fluid set of practices organized to accomplish specific goals, one sees that each cultural community may have a unique set of "best practices" to promote socialization and developmental goals for its children. These practices and goals are situated within the broader community context that includes political, social, and economic history.

The second assumption is that culture is equivalent to one's ethnic or linguistic background. Looking at culture as a set of practices rather than as a person's background provides a more powerful way to understand variations within ethnic and linguistic groups than simply comparing attributes across groups. As teachers, early care providers, and researchers often note, it is typical for more differences than similarities to appear among children from the same ethnic or linguistic backgrounds. Families from similar ethnic or linguistic backgrounds do not necessarily have the same routines, goals, or practices. Routines, goals, and practices are developed in the context of a family's history, including cultural and linguistic heritage, but they vary across regions and from country to country and are usually associated with the immediate and recent social, political, and economic goals of the community. The cultural practices, or routine ways of doing things, define the cultural context in which humans develop. Using this approach, practitioners and researchers can explore how culturally based practices with children drive developmental outcomes rather than

focus exclusively on how developmental outcomes differ across ethnic and linguistic groups. The following vignette illustrates this concept. ^[22]

Naptime Struggles



Figure 2.3: Children patterns vary based on home culture. ^[23]

José is a 17-month-old child whose family lives in an apartment in a large city located close to the Mexican border. His family has recently moved to the United States and has been living with his aunt and her four children. José has been attending a local infant/toddler program for almost two months. His teachers report that naptime is particularly difficult for José. Although obviously very tired, José struggles to transition to his cot and often lies on the floor and cries, which disturbs the other children and often wakes them.

José's primary care teacher has tried carrying José to his cot and giving him a book or favorite toy to help him calm down; however, José rolls off the cot and onto the floor and continues to cry. When José finally does fall asleep, it is usually time for the children to get up and have a snack. The lead teacher, Carla, decides to bring up this issue to her supervisor during her next reflective supervision meeting.

When asked to describe how José's behavior during naptime makes her feel, Carla shares that she feels sad for José because he is so obviously distressed and that she wishes she could do something to help him. She also feels that since José has been in the program for almost two months, he should be able to make the transition to naptime more easily. When asked how José's behavior makes her feel in her role as lead teacher, Carla shares that she feels ineffective as a teacher and worries about the effect that José's behavior has on the other children. She also worries about how she and her assistant will get their lunch breaks since all children need to be asleep in order for one of them to leave the classroom.

Carla's supervisor suggests that she do a home visit to get to know the family better and learn more about the family's caregiving routines. During the home visit, Carla learns that José has slept with his mother since birth and that in José's country of origin, children typically sleep with a parent until another sibling is born, at which time they generally move to an older sibling's bed. When discussing this with her supervisor, Carla comes to understand that co-sleeping reflects a goal of José's cultural community, which is to foster interdependence. ^[24]

As this vignette illustrates, the interdependence valued in José's home is dramatically different from the emphasis on self-reliance and autonomy found in his early care program. Researchers have reported that environments where sleep patterns are different from those of the home setting can lead to uncertainty for children (Provence, Naylor, and Patterson 1977) and that sleep patterns are often among the final practices to change when a family moves to a new country (Farooqui, Perry, and Beevers 1991). José experiences very different practices in the early care program, which are based on the goal of independence, from those he experiences at home. By making a home visit to learn more about family practices, Carla has taken an important first step toward understanding José's behavior and creating a sensitive and responsive classroom. ^[25]

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2.2: The Role of Culture in Development

Although the early childhood field has a long history of commitment to developing culturally appropriate approaches to educating young children (“multicultural education”), it still struggles with understanding the role of culture in the development of our youngest children (Maschinot 2008; Derman-Sparks and Olsen Edwards 2010). To develop a culturally responsive approach, it is essential to understand that what children learn from families and teachers is an idea system that extends deep into the values of a group of people. Learning goes far beyond the things generally associated with culture, such as art, music, styles of dress, or holidays. As a child acquires cultural ways of being, these cultural rules for behavior impact identity by giving children the tools to understand their family/community and be understood in it.

Acquiring the idea system of the group is so powerful that it gives children the ability to interact with the group. For example, babies are born with the capability to make sounds; however, those sounds become meaningful only as they communicate with their families. Through communication the sounds are shaped and organized into the words and sentences the babies’ families use to share meaning. Thus, as children come to know the ideas that govern speech and language in their community, they gain the power to communicate and to represent themselves in the world.

So, when teachers treat culture with an almost exclusive emphasis on the celebrations, styles of dress, art, music, and food habits, they fail to appreciate the depth of cultural impact and the idea system at work in the process of development. Although a child’s identity is impacted by participation in family cultural rituals, the focus neither starts nor ends there. Surrounding children with artifacts and customs that are a part of their history, homes, and communities is important. However, when that approach becomes the sole emphasis in attempts to embrace culture, it diverts attention from the more fundamental role that culture plays in the development of children’s social, emotional, physical, and intellectual well-being. The challenge for teachers of young children is to understand the importance of culture to human development and to move beyond mere cultural appreciation and enrichment to cultural empowerment. ^[26]



Figure 2.4: Children learn by being around others that are different than themselves. ^[27]

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2.3: Myths About Culture

Myth 1, Essentialism : It is possible to learn all there is to know about a culture by studying its traditions, beliefs, practices, and attitudes.

Truth : It is nearly impossible to reduce the essential and distinguishing features of any culture or cultural group to descriptive statements or lists of characteristics

Myth 2, Overgeneralization : Cultural practices and beliefs apply in the same way to all members of a cultural group.

Truth : Cultures are dynamic and constantly evolving in response to such factors as environmental conditions, new challenges, technology, and acculturative pressures resulting from close encounters with other cultural groups. Cultures that are in proximity borrow from and are influenced by one another.

Myth 3, Assumption of stability : Cultures are static, constant, and stable.

Truth : The shared system of beliefs, morals, values, attitudes, practices, roles, artifacts, symbols, and language that make up a culture are adaptive, dynamic, and in constant flux in response to changes in the social context. Cultures change in response to strains, opportunities, and altered social landscapes. Learning and relearning must take place continually.

Myth 4, Single-culture assumption : Within a home and family, a single culture predominates.

Truth : Within in a single family there may be blending of several distinct cultures and ethnic identities. This means that individuals living with a single family may reflect not one, but several cultural traditions. ^[28]

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2.4: Responsiveness to Culture and Language Supports Children's Learning

Responsive environments create a climate of respect for each child's culture and language when teachers and other program staff partner and regularly communicate with family members. They work to get to know the cultural strengths each child brings to their early childhood education program. An essential part of being culturally and linguistically responsive is to value and support each child's use of home language, for continued use and development of the child's home language is beneficial, as is becoming multilingual (learning English in addition to any home languages).

Equally important are nurturing interactions with children and their families in which “. . . teachers attempt, as much as possible, to learn about the history, beliefs, and practices of the children & families they serve. . . .” In addition to being responsive to the cultural history, beliefs, values, ways of communicating, and practices of children and families, teachers create learning environments that include resources such as pictures, displays, and books that are culturally rich and supportive of a diverse population, particularly the cultures and languages of the children and families in their preschool setting. Community members add to the cultural richness of a preschool setting by sharing their art, music, dance, traditions, and stories. ^[29]

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2.5: Summary

Culture can be defined in many ways, is complex, and is continually developing. It affects the way children and their families behave, what they value, and their identities. It is critical that early childhood educators partner with families to understand, value, respect, and honor the individual cultures of the children in your early childhood education classroom.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Teachers' Professional Identity and Becoming Equity Minded

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Analyze how teachers' professional identities are formed
- Discuss how teachers gain knowledge and experience in working with children and families

[3.1: Introduction](#)

[3.2: Development of Teachers' Identity](#)

[3.3: Summary](#)

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3.1: Introduction

In addition to examining how children develop their identities, we must also reflect on our own identities and how it effects our teaching. We must also reflect on how our identities were created. Most importantly, how does our identity effect our teaching methods and the children we work with?

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3.2: Development of Teachers' Identity

As our identity affects so much about the way we respond, it is critical to look at our own identity as individuals and in our professional role of early childhood educators. In addition to developing a personal and social identity, teachers also develop a specific professional identity. This process begins during childhood and continues throughout the lifespan.

The professional identity of teachers includes the following: their personal values and beliefs, their professional values and belief, and their cultural experiences which they learned in their childhood and their cultural experiences that they have accepted into their daily lives. In reflecting on these experiences, it affords teachers opportunities to gain deeper understanding of themselves which helps them to understand others. It provides them opportunities to gain empathy and understanding of others that can only be accomplished when we understand ourselves.

Most early childhood professionals had experiences during their schooling that have shaped their ideas of teaching. ^[41]



“I do not exactly remember what I, as a child, wanted to be when I grew up. I think it was not a concern of mine. But I recall a certain episode, already in 4th grade, in which I answered I wanted to be “a teacher of children”. By that time, my representation of a teacher was “someone who knows a lot of things”. Later, throughout the years, I wanted to be other things, depending on my interests:... It was only later, when I was already in college, studying to be a teacher, that the desire of the 4th-grade girl intensified. It was the experience in a summer camp, with children aged 4 to 12, which made me want to know more about the world of the child. Now, looking back, I think, humorously, that this profession, at that time, was still “not yet born” and that, somehow, I was expecting its birth [emphasis added].”

Miranda (student teacher) ^[42]

The teaching profession is a journey of reflection to learn more about ourselves in this role. As we learn more about who we are, we are able to understand our teaching philosophies and our role in promoting equitable learning environments. The journey is one of progress not perfection. As we interact with the children and families we serve, we become more aware of our role.

Learning is inherent to the human condition. Every human has the capacity to learn throughout the lifespan. Education provides opportunities to improve oneself, acquire and/or modify knowledge, gain competency, and construct meaning (which may be the same as acquiring and/or modifying information so may not need to include that or use that instead of the former). We do this through the experiences we have, the interactions with others (development of interpersonal relationships), observing other teachers in action and applying what we have observed and learned in our course of study.

This learning includes:

- Knowledge for practice is the one which derives from academic research (formal knowledge) and from which teachers structure their practice, i.e., it is the application of formal knowledge to practical teaching situations.
- Knowledge in practice is the one acquired during the activity, since teachers' knowledge is immersed in their practice, in what they perform about practice, in questioning, and in the narrative of this practice. Knowledge comes from action/experience, from the understanding, and from the reflections and decisions which teachers make every day in schools.
- Knowledge of practice is what Formosinho (2009) calls the knowledge built in a collective manner inside local communities, formed by teachers who work in school development, education, or collaborative questioning projects.

It is from the gaining of knowledge and engagement in learning experiences (action) that it becomes possible to articulate theory and practice. The teacher learns how to learn and learns how to teach.



Figure 4.1: Part of the student teaching experience is the formation of the professional identity. ^[43]

This group culture and the feeling of belonging to a professional family (Tejada Fernández, 2009a, 2009b) constitute a complex, interactive, and multidirectional process between the student and the teacher, in which relationships are based on ethics, respect, and by valuing social differences (Tejada-Fernández, Carvalho, & Bueno, 2014). ^[44]

In response to increased accountability measures and evaluation systems, schools adopt new approaches and innovations. Such activities often require teachers to adopt new roles and responsibilities, develop new knowledge and skill, and reconfigure their relationships with peers and administrators. As a result, teachers build new professional identities in response to the underlying question—who am I as a teacher? ^[45]

Becoming Equity Minded

Once the student teacher becomes a teacher in an early childhood classroom, the journey of gaining knowledge and experience continues. This journey includes taking the path towards social equity. This requires teachers reflecting on the underlying reasons for the way they educate and care for children so that they can become equity-minded. One way to define equity-minded.



Think About It...

Based on what you've read and learned so far, how would you define equity-minded?



Figure 4.2: Teachers must reflect on their role in creating social equity. ^[46]

It is important for teachers to act as critical thinkers and not just supposedly neutral performers of what is considered to be effective teaching. Very often teaching young children is seen as just supervising play, managing behaviors, and implementing activities with children. But teaching should be considered to be an important responsibility, in which the teachers use what they know about

children and their families to create a developmentally appropriate curriculum and build strong, reciprocal relationships with children and families based on their cultural and social contexts.

This culturally responsive approach, supports children to become participants in a democratic society and work towards equity. This involves taking an active responsibility in asking fundamental questions about what they actually teach, and especially about the broader aims which they wish to achieve, and about their role in developing a democratic and just society. Books, such as this one and the course it was written for will support your journey as an equity minded early childhood educator.

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3.3: Summary

As future teachers pursue their education, they build knowledge, skills, and experiences in working with children and families. This process in addition to the personal identities, contributes to their professional identity. It's important for teachers to be self-aware and self-reflective. That process will support teachers in becoming equity-minded professionals.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Effectively Negotiating and Resolving Conflict Related to Issues of Diversity

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Articulate the importance of celebrating diversity
- Discuss why cultural differences may lead to conflict between families and programs
- Explain how to develop relationships with families that are inclusive and supportive
- Outline how to create practices and policies that respond to differences respectfully
- Describe three steps to deal with cultural differences in early childhood education programs

Working in an early education setting, with children, family and coworkers from varying backgrounds, conflict is inevitable. However, if managed correctly, conflict can be a learning and growing experience for all.

[4.1: Differences and Conflict](#)

[4.2: Preventing Conflict](#)

[4.3: Navigating Cultural Differences](#)

[4.4: Dealing with Differences](#)

[4.5: Summary](#)

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4.1: Differences and Conflict

Working in an early education setting, with children, family and coworkers from varying backgrounds, conflict is inevitable. However, if managed correctly, conflict can be a learning and growing experience for all.

In her book *Diversity in Early Care and Education: Honoring Differences*, Janet Gonzalez-Mena discusses the need to honor, learn about and explore not only other cultures different than ours, but acknowledge how our own beliefs play a role in our professional caretaking roles. She shares her own process, “They say we teach what we need most to learn. I am a good example. I’m working on my dialoguing skills. The problem is that when I have a strong reaction to something that doesn’t fit my system, I usually consider it a problem.....My natural reaction is to become defensive and start arguing.” This is a common response for many because our upbringing has taught us that our way is the ‘right’ way, so anything different simply doesn’t feel right.

As professionals, it is imperative we build relationships with families and create a classroom of inclusiveness that celebrates diversity.

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4.2: Preventing Conflict

Issues of Social Justice in the Early Childhood Classroom

Summary

Some conflict can be prevented when we build relationships with families based on a willingness to listen to hear about who they are and what they want for their children. Here are some cultural considerations to keep in mind as you work to understand the experiences and values families have and how you can best meet their needs:

- Many families are most comfortable keeping young children at home with a parent, relative, or friend, especially with families from the same cultural background. So, when they do rely on out-of-home child care, they may experience some discomfort and may not be aware of licensing requirements and restrictions.
- Some cultures may expect that the mother's primary role is taking care of children and the home. However, both parents may need to find work due to financial need and thus depend on out-of-home child care. This can create guilt, shame, fear, and discomfort.
- Families with limited English skills are likely to have difficulty gathering information about the varied early care and education options and may rely on word of mouth or recommendations from others within their ethnic or religious community.
- Families may seek reassurance that early care and education providers understand and respect their family's religion and will not inadvertently violate the family's religious practices (e.g., abstaining from pork products).
- Families of a child with a disability may not be aware of the legal educational requirements, learning possibilities, and school options for children with disabilities.
- Hiring staff from the same culture and language as families and providing opportunities for families from the same cultural or linguistic backgrounds to connect may encourage family engagement and mutual support.
- Some cultures show respect for teachers by not being intrusive and interfering with their job (e.g., not offering suggestions or sharing negative opinions). By American standards, this can look like lack of interest. Families may not know the expectations for family engagement in school.

We can start conversations that will help us understand where families are coming from and how we can effectively and respectfully engage and communicate with them. Questions to ask might include:

- What are some ways staff can learn more about your perspectives and needs?
- How would you like to communicate and partner with staff?
- Describe what school was like in your country of origin (if the family has immigrated or are refugees). ^[85]

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4.3: Navigating Cultural Differences

Cultural differences can lead to conflicts. For example, people may disagree on practices for handling a baby, responding to crying, or feeding. Home visit staff may be concerned over how and when to intervene in family arguments. Staff and families in early childhood education programs may differ about how programs should support children's home or native language. Given the wide range of cultural ideas, it is not surprising that adults can have differences that are rooted in the core of their being.

Gonzalez-Mena (1992, 2001, 2008) indicated that these disagreements may be when adults from different cultural backgrounds may find that their familiar ways of working with children are different or when adults within the same culture can disagree. In both of these situations of conflict between program staff and families, Gonzalez-Mena identified four possible outcomes:

1. All sides gain understanding, negotiate, and/or compromise, leading to resolution of the conflict.
2. Program staff understand the families' perspective(s) and change their practices.
3. Families take on the perspective of the program staff and change their practices.
4. No resolution is reached (here, the conflict may continue or intensify; or both sides can cope with the differences).

Of course, conflicts can occur over numerous issues. To help program staff make progress, Gonzalez-Mena challenges them to question their own assumptions about child development practices (e.g., "My way of thinking about X is not the only way to think about it. My way of doing Practice Y is not the only way to work with the child."). Once this commitment to test one's own assumptions is in place, two goals for a conflict situation are: (1) to minimize (or eliminate) extreme differences in practices; and (2) to resolve the situation for the benefit of the child. Program staff are encouraged to take a child centered look at any situation of conflicting practices. ^[86]

The process for each varies greatly not only based on cultures, but even within similar cultures. These practices can often times go against program policy and best practice as we have been taught in the field. ^[87]



Pin it! Differences in Feeding Practices

The following is a scenario from the NAEYC's publication, *Diversity and Infant/Toddler Caregiving* :

"Junior, who is new to the center, is excited when he sees a bowl of food. The baby makes happy sounds, kicks his legs, and waves his arms. But when Helen puts Junior in the high chair and places the bowl in front of him, he just sits there and makes no attempt to feed himself. He looks confused and becomes distressed. Finally he slumps over, a glazed look in his eyes.

His mother explains later that she has taught Junior not to touch his food. In fact, her son has never been in a high chair; he has always been fed on his mother's lap, wrapped up tightly in a blanket to discourage him from interfering with her." ^[88]

Gonzalez-Mena and Bhavnagri suggest that when the family and program do not agree about a practice or policy, early childhood educators should ask themselves:

1. What is the family's cultural perspective on the issue?
2. How do the family's child care practices relate to their cultural perspective?
3. What are the family's goals for the child? How has the family's culture influenced these goals?
4. In review of these goals, is the family's practice in the child's best interest?
5. Is there any sound research that shows that the family's practice is doing actual harm?
6. Is the program's practice or policy universally applicable, or is it better suited to a particular culture?
7. Did the family choose the program because of its particular philosophy, even if it is based on a different culture from their own?
8. Have program staff members attempted to fully understand the family's rationale for its practices, the complexity of the issues, and other contributing factors?
9. Have staff members attempted to fully explain the rationale for program practices? Have they looked at how their own culture influences their perspective?

10. What are some creative resolutions that address the concerns of both partners and the program? ^[89]

The point is to begin and continue to dialogue with families and to exchange information with the goal of resolving the conflict for the benefit of the child. The “bottom line” is really: What is in the best interest of the child? As stated in the National Association for the Education of Young Children’s Code of Ethical Conduct , our first and foremost ethical responsibility to children is to do no harm.

By learning more about the goals that families have for their children, and about the types of behaviors or practices that families prioritize and implement as they raise their children, program staff can more easily match the learning experiences of the classroom to those of the home. For example, if a teacher is concerned that a 3-year-old in her class is not skilled with using a fork, she should first find out if this is a goal of the family. Do they scoop their food at home using spoons? Do they use chopsticks? Do they feed the child or allow the child to self-feed? It is best for the teacher to check what the family practices and goals are before they misjudge what this child needs from them in terms of support and understanding.

According to National Association for the Education of Young Children’s developmentally appropriate practice one of the tenets is to be culturally responsive. In preparing an environment that supports children and families, we need to ensure that we have considered the beliefs, values, and needs of the family to deliver curriculum that addresses the child both individually and as a group. ^[90]

These exercises can be done individually and at a staff/team meeting. It’s important to involve the family and all caregivers as a way to ensure all perspectives are heard. Now that questions have been identified, having the conversation to gather the information is next; however, this comes with challenges. As you enter into the conversation, it’s important to put personal biases and beliefs aside and be ready to actively listen to hear and learn about the family and their point of view. ^[91]

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4.4: Dealing with Differences

The Program for Infant/Toddler Caregivers (PITC) has outlined three steps in their training Dealing with Differences: Acknowledge, Ask, Adapt that can be used in early childhood programs that serve children of all ages.

Step 1: Acknowledge

How does the caregiver recognize the need for communication with the family? How does the caregiver's attitude convey sincere interest and response? What can the caregiver say to the family to communicate awareness that there is a problem they need to jointly solve?

- Take time to think about how you feel about this issue and get clarity on the reasons behind your feelings.
- Listen carefully to the other person's concern. If you bring up the concern, do it respectfully with an attitude of wanting to understand the issues.

Step 2: Ask

What questions can the caregiver ask the families to get information that will help her or him understand more precisely the families' point of view?

- The next step is about data gathering, trying to get to the real sources of conflict or misunderstanding for the family, the child or you. Ask questions that seek to clarify (and allow families to ask questions to understand the program's point-of-view).
- Pay attention to verbal and nonverbal responses. Restate what you think is being said, take time to be sure you are meaning the same thing in the language you are using.

Step 3: Adapt

How does the caregiver work with the family to define the issues and boundaries of the problem? Does the caregiver seek "common ground" as the basis for negotiation? How does the caregiver open up a negotiation with the family about what to do?

- Once the issues have been defined, seek out the common ground by stating your areas of greatest importance to each other. Listen carefully for areas of common agreement.
- Negotiate around the areas of important agreement and boundaries. Come to a resolution that addresses the real/major issues. Sometimes we have to agree to disagree. ^[92]

While using this method is a great start to get the most desired results, there will be instances when it won't take place. A few outcomes to become familiar and comfortable with are different outcomes that may come during the conversation.

- Sometimes there may be a resolution through mutual understanding and negotiation. Both parties see the other's perspective which is where both parties give a little or a lot.
- There may be a resolution that takes place through gradual education and understanding of the caregiver and seeing the perspective of the family.
- There can also be a resolution through the process of family education. This happens when the family sees the caregiver's perspective and decides to change.
- Lastly, and it's common, there can be no resolution. When this happens, the professional should look at Community Care Licensing Regulations(CCL), as well as internal policies and procedures to ensure no laws or rules are being violated. There are times when internal processes are created, but can be adjusted to meet the individual needs to families. These discussions and determinations should be made with the assistance and input of the site administrators. In some circumstances, the program and family may come to a mutual decision that the program is not a good fit for the family's needs.

Conflicts related to diversity are inevitable and should not be seen or approached in a negative way but rather with the goal of partnering to create the best environment for the child to thrive while in your care. The process of partnering takes time, mutual understanding and for at least one person to take the first, often uncomfortable step.

A few things to remember:

1. All families want what's best for their child and are doing what they believe is best

2. Be curious: what are the expectations the family has from you? From the program and for their child? This will help guide any conversations and interactions.
3. Become self-aware: what makes you uncomfortable? What are your personal beliefs?



Think About It...

Think about a time you had conflict related to diversity with a child in your classroom or family member. How could you have used these tools to create an equitable outcome?

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4.5: Summary

We know that being respectful of difference is valuable in an early learning setting. As indicated, these differences can lead to conflicts between families, early childhood professionals, and the program their child is enrolled in. With strong relationships, some of that conflict can be prevented. Early childhood educators can be reflective when disagreements over practices and policies occur. And they can use the three steps outlined by PITC's Dealing with Differences: Acknowledge, Ask, Adapt training to help mitigate the conflict respectfully.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

5: Race, Ethnicity, and Language

Learning Objectives

- Explain the following laws within the Ideal Gas Law

5.1: Introduction

5.2: Culture, Race, and Ethnicity

5.3: Immigrant and Refugee Populations

5.4: Dual Language Learners

5.5: Summary

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5.1: Introduction

Some of the ways the children and families you will serve are related to race, ethnicity, national origin, and language. This chapter will explore the race and ethnicity and demographics of young children in California, how collectivist and individualistic cultures differ, information about immigration, including refugees and asylees, and children that are dual language learners. Guidance and suggestions are provided to help programs use what they know about these in the children and families they serve to support and include all families effectively.

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5.2: Culture, Race, and Ethnicity

Introduction

Chapter 8: Race, Ethnicity, and Language

Introduction

Culture, Race, and Ethnicity

Culture, language, ethnicity, race, and national origin are related concepts by which individuals are assigned to social groups, but they are not one and the same. For example, persons of African descent living in the Caribbean, Latin America, Nigeria, South Africa, or the United States may be classified as falling within the same racial category, but they belong to different cultural groups. Jamaican or Haitian families living in California may be lumped into the same racial or ethnic category as Black or African American families that have lived in the United States for generations. Although language, ethnicity, and national origin may be associated with culture, none of them alone define a specific cultural group. For example, Spanish speakers in Europe, Mexico, Africa, Central or South America, and the United States share a language with common features, but may have divergent cultures and self-identify with different racial groups.

National origin—such as being from China, Sudan, or Peru—does not sufficiently specify a cultural group because within each of these nations exist groups with several distinct cultures. Racial group is sometimes confused with cultural group. Race is a social construct that has no basis in culture, biology, or genetics. Race is a social category that is based either on self-identification or how individuals are seen by others. This means that the traditional ethnic and racial categories such as those used in the U.S. Census are social categories that fail to specify culture even though they continue to be interpreted by many as cultural categories. ^[93]

In the U.S. Census, there are five categories of race:

- American Indian or Alaska Native. A person having origins in any of the original peoples of North and South America (including Central America), and who maintains tribal affiliation or community attachment.
- Asian. A person having origins in any of the original peoples of the Far East, Southeast Asia, or the Indian subcontinent including, for example, Cambodia, China, India, Japan, Korea, Malaysia, Pakistan, the Philippine Islands, Thailand, and Vietnam.
- Black or African American. A person having origins in any of the black racial groups of Africa. Terms such as "Haitian" can be used in addition to "Black or African American."
- Hispanic or Latino. A person of Cuban, Mexican, Puerto Rican, South or Central American, or other Spanish culture or origin, regardless of race. The term, "Spanish origin," can be used in addition to "Hispanic or Latino."
- Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander. A person having origins in any of the original peoples of Hawaii, Guam, Samoa, or other Pacific Islands.
- White. A person having origins in any of the original peoples of Europe, the Middle East, or North Africa.

Ethnicity comes closer to defining cultural groups than race or national origin, but it is not a perfect match. Ethnicity refers to a group's identity and denotes a people bound by a common broad past. Members of an ethnic group often share a common ancestry, history, and sometimes language. To the extent that an ethnic group uses a common language, shares practices and beliefs, and has a common history, members of ethnic groups may be said to share a culture. However, ethnicity and culture are not always the same. Individuals may not necessarily identify strongly with the group to which they are assigned (in the minds of others). Nevertheless, ethnicity is a useful concept because it signals a group identity and a sense of connection and belonging. ^[94]

In the U.S. Census there are only two ethnicity categories : "Hispanic or Latino" and "Not Hispanic or Latino." ^[95] But the idea that all Latinos are white or nonwhite is inaccurate. The idea that a large subgroup all has one big group identity is superficial and does not represent the reality today in California. ^[96]

Demographic Information for Young Children in California

In 2010, of the more than 2.5 million children under the age of five living in California, about half of these children were Latino (U.S. Census Bureau 2010). It is important to note that Latinos may be of any race, according to the U.S. Census Bureau. White non-Latino children make up 30 percent of children under five in California, Asian-Pacific Islanders make up 10 percent, Black or

African Americans make up 6 percent, and the remaining 4 percent represent a wide range of ethnic groups (Whitebook, Kipnis, and Bellm 2008). ^[97]



Figure 8.1: Recognizing the importance of families and culture is important. ^[98]

Collectivist Versus Individualist Cultures

A feature that has often been used to distinguish societies and cultural groups is where they fall along a continuum from individualist to collectivist orientations.

In collectivist societies, the self is defined principally in terms of identity with the group (Roland 1988). When what may be good for the whole competes with what may be good for the individual, the good of the whole takes precedence. In societies at the collectivist end of the continuum, children are imbued with the sense that their behavior will reflect for the good or the bad on the rest of the group. They may be instilled with a sense of shame if they behave in a way that reflects badly on the group.

In a family with an individualist cultural orientation, each child has his or her own possessions. In some families with a more collectivistic perspective, private ownership is downplayed and everything is shared. When the family has that perspective, they may require sharing from infancy on; whereas someone with a child development background or a more individualistic orientation might hold the view that the child must understand the concept of ownership before he or she can become a truly sharing person and that understanding usually starts in the second year of life. Sharing of the program's toys and materials is expected; however, if the child brings something from home, possessiveness is expected and there may be different rules about that in the program.

Individualist versus collectivist orientation should be understood as a tendency in a society rather than an absolute characteristic. Few would claim that pure forms of individualist and collectivist societies exist. Both orientations exist in most cultural groups, to varying degrees. This tendency is especially relevant in the context of teaching and learning, where children whose families emphasize a collectivist orientation may be more familiar with learning settings that focus more on group experiences and learning, while individualist orientations focus on individual work and learning, not in relation to the group. Individualist and collectivist orientations coexist within the same society. ^[99]

What Programs Can Do

Because of the diversity and dynamism of cultures represented in California's early childhood programs, efforts to profile cultural groups would be quickly outdated. In addition to the practices in Chapters 3 and 4, programs can also use Culturally Responsive Strength-Based (CRSB) Framework, which is used by Head Start, to address diversity. This framework presents the big picture and identifies the program pieces that support the growth and development of all children.

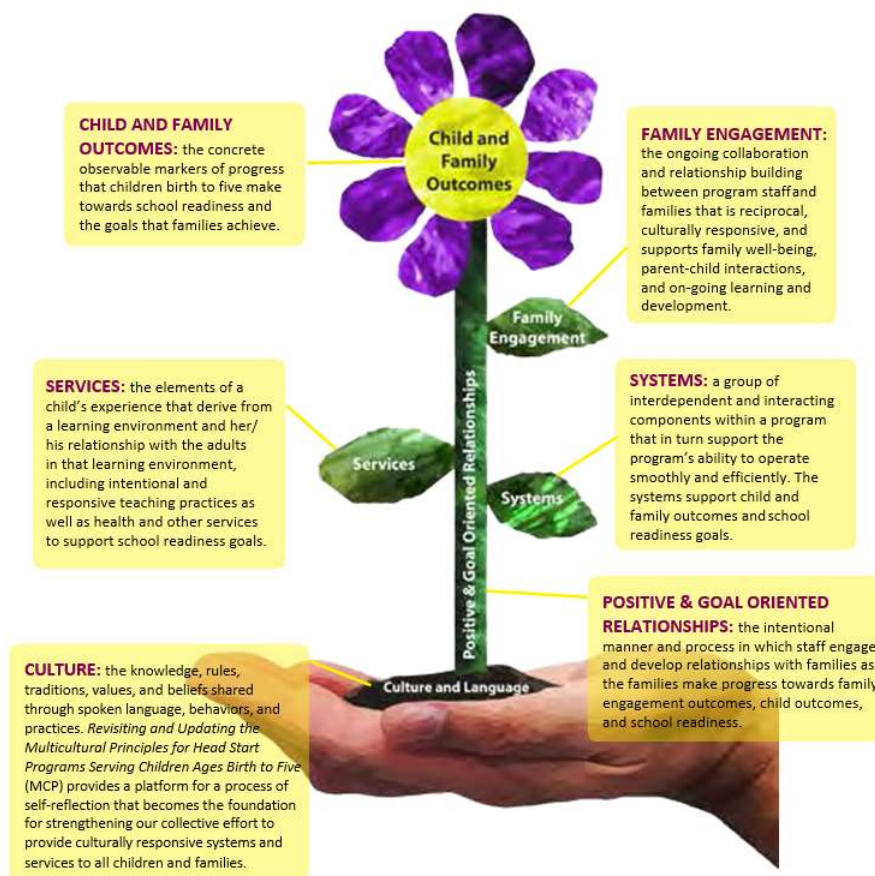


Figure 8.2: The elements of the CRSB Framework. ^[100]

Coupled with a culturally responsive approach, the CRSB Framework is a strength-based approach. The focus is on what children know and can do as opposed to what they cannot do or what they do not know. Cultural, family, and individual strengths are emphasized, not just the negative and proposed interventions to “fix the problem” that resides with the children, their families, and/or their communities.

“

The strengths approach has a contagious quality and it intuitively makes sense to those who reflect a “cup half full” attitude in life. — Hamilton & Zimmerman, 2012

If we ask people to look for deficits, they will usually find them, and their view of the situation will be colored by this. If we ask people to look for successes, they will usually find it, and their view of the situation will be colored by this. — Kral, 1989 (as cited in Hamilton & Zimmerman, 2012) ^[101]

The CRSB Framework should be used with the understanding that children are influenced by many environments, as represented in a bioecological systems model. A bioecological systems model captures the variety of environments that impact individual development over the course of a lifetime. Young children do not live in a vacuum, but co-exist in many environments that affect their development, starting with the family, extending into the community, and reaching out into the economic and political spheres.

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5.3: Immigrant and Refugee Populations

An immigrant is a person who has been granted permission by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) to reside permanently in the United States as a Lawful Permanent Resident (LPR). They are eligible to apply for citizenship after five years. In general, immigrants come to the U.S. voluntarily, while refugees are forced to leave their homeland, often with little time for preparation. Some people entering the U.S. are considered undocumented immigrants (those who enter the country without invitation or application; or who enter legally as a visitor, student, or temporary employee, and stay after their visa expires). In addition, some groups are awarded a temporary status (such as “Temporary Protected Status”) by USCIS due to extraordinary and temporary conditions in designated countries that would threaten personal safety. This type of status can be terminated at any time, and it therefore provides an uncertain future to those it covers.

Refugees are a special class of immigrants who have fled their countries of nationality and have been determined unable or unwilling to return to their countries due to a well-founded fear of persecution. Refugees are screened and approved for resettlement to the United States by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). Refugee migration may involve a long and difficult journey, long waits in refugee camps or other countries, extreme deprivation, and/or physical and emotional trauma, including torture. Asylees are approved according to similar criteria, but apply for asylum after they arrive in the United States.



Figure 8.3: This man was a refugee from Togo in 2005. ^[102]

In absolute numbers, the United States has a larger immigrant population than any other country, with 47 million immigrants as of 2015. ^[103]

What Programs Can Do

For refugee and immigrant children and youth, it is important to help them nurture a strong and positive connection to their ethnic heritage, to maintain their home language, and to develop a positive bicultural identity as Americans. This helps to keep families strong and thereby provides the support that children need to succeed in this country.

Refugee and immigrant families come to the United States with a wealth of parenting strengths, drawing on culture, tradition, and family experience. Like most parents in the U.S. they tend to be responsible and nurturing, and have often sacrificed tremendously to provide their children with an opportunity for safety and success in this new country. At the same time, families that are new to the U.S. have often experienced incredible loss and trauma, including the loss of extended family members, community, and homeland, and they must adapt to new traditions and lifestyles that are often at odds with their own beliefs and practices. Refugee and immigrant families also must overcome cultural, language, and practical barriers to learn about and access the community services that are available to them as having newly arrived to our country.

It is important for early childhood education programs to use family- and community-centered, strengths-based approaches with refugees and immigrants. This helps to maximize family and community input and build upon cultural assets in order to successfully engage and serve families who have newly arrived in the U.S. ^[104]

All providers can support families in identifying high quality early care and education options that can support a child’s development and strengthen school readiness. Understanding the opportunities, activities, and options for family engagement can help families form meaningful home-school partnerships that benefit the entire family, program and community.

Learning more about families is an important part of creating a relationship and gaining valuable information about a child’s culture. Consider using these or similar conversation starters:

- Describe what school was like in your country of origin.
- Who cared for your child when you needed support in your country of origin?
- How do you currently communicate and partner with staff at your child's school?
- What are some ways staff can learn more about your perspectives and needs?

Some cultural considerations that you should remember as you help families navigate an unfamiliar system of early childhood education:

- Many families are most comfortable keeping young children at home with a parent, relative, or friend, especially with families from the same cultural background. Some refugee families using in-home childcare providers may not be aware of licensing requirements and restrictions.
- Some cultures may expect that the mother's primary role is taking care of children and the home. However, both parents may need to find work due to financial need, or due to resettlement program requirements.
- Families with limited English skills are likely to have difficulty gathering information about the varied early care and education options and may rely on word of mouth or recommendations from others within their ethnic or religious community.
- Families may seek reassurance that early care and education providers understand and respect their family's religion and will not inadvertently violate the family's religious practices (e.g., Muslim children abstaining from pork products).
- Families of a child with a disability may not be aware of the legal educational requirements, learning possibilities, and school options for children with disabilities.
- Hiring staff from the same culture and language as families and providing opportunities for families from the same cultural or linguistic backgrounds to connect may encourage family engagement and mutual support. However, it is important to identify any areas of discrimination or political conflict that program staff or families from the same region may have experienced.
- Some cultures show respect for teachers by not being intrusive and interfering with their job (e.g., not offering suggestions or sharing negative opinions). Families may not know the expectations for family engagement in school and their respect may look like lack of interest.
- Home-based programs may be an effective service model for some families that are less comfortable with center-based programming, or those who do not drive. Home visits can help to build trust and relationships for future center-based enrollment.

As you support the families, here are some valuable things that you can share with families about family engagement and the central role that families have in early childhood education programs:

- Early care and education plays a vital role in providing the environment and support to prepare children for success in school and in life. The quality of the relationships and experiences provided has long-term effects on their development, capacity to learn, and ability to regulate emotions.
- Family engagement has a positive impact on children's learning and skill development. Families and staff are encouraged to engage in open communication and develop meaningful relationships.
- To ensure responsive engagement, it is important for staff to build trusting relationships with families over time. Through these relationships, staff can learn about family's culture, values, and beliefs (e.g., health and nutrition practices, child rearing practices, home language, family composition, cultural celebrations, etc.).
- Families can offer their knowledge, skills, culture, and language by participating in decision-making classroom, and community events, at parent-teacher conferences, and as a volunteer in the program.
- Translation and interpretation services can support family engagement. This includes face-to-face experiences e.g., meetings and events, as well as written communication from the program and are essential to engage families who staff cannot speak or communicate with directly.
- The frequency of family engagement opportunities will vary from program to program. Programs will often meet with families at the time of enrollment to share information, to discuss a family's interest and ability to participate, and to consider cultural and linguistic needs or preferences.
- In the U.S., all children, including children with disabilities, are required to start attending school when they reach their state's compulsory school attendance age (generally between 5 and 7 years of age but dependent upon each state's laws). ^[105]

When integrating immigrant and refugee families into the community, celebrate cultural diversity. Work to create a welcoming and inclusive learning environment that respects families and engages them in meaningful ways. ^[106]

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5.4: Dual Language Learners

Dual language learner (DLL) means a child who is acquiring two or more languages at the same time, or a child who is learning a second language while continuing to develop their first language. The term "dual language learner" may encompass or overlap substantially with other terms frequently used, such as bilingual or multilingual, English language learner (ELL), Limited English Proficient (LEP), English learner, and children who speak a Language Other Than English (LOTE). To be as inclusive as possible, in this book we have chosen to use dual language learner and multilingual in most contexts.

Language is essential in developing a strong sense of culture and overall learning. It has been noted that children who are dual language learners (DLL) form a substantial and growing segment of the preschool population in California. Sixty percent of all children under five are English learners. ^[107] For the majority of these children, Spanish is the home language, followed by Vietnamese, Cantonese, Hmong, Tagalog, Korean, and other languages.” ^[108]

Over 200 languages are known to be spoken and read in California, with Spanish used as the state's "alternative" language. California has more than 100 indigenous languages, making California one of the most linguistically diverse areas in the world. All of California's indigenous languages are endangered, although there are now efforts toward language revitalization. ^[109]



Figure 8.4: Teachers can supplement oral language with gestures. ^[110]

Children who are dual language learners bring a wealth of ability and knowledge as well as varied cultural backgrounds to early childhood settings; they also require curricular adaptations to make the most of their abilities while they progress toward full English proficiency. Current knowledge, based on successful practices and sound research, strongly suggests that specific teaching strategies, individualized interaction approaches, and enhanced environments are critical to the long-term success of young children who are not native speakers of English. ^[111]

What Programs Can Do

The California Department of Education has developed the following guiding principles to assist practitioners in their work with children who are dual language learners:

- Families matter: The education of children who are dual language learners is enhanced when preschool programs and families form meaningful relationships. It is through these relationships that teachers will not only learn about home language use but the hopes and aspirations that parents have for their children's overall development.
- Recognize existing language and literacy strengths in the home language: Engaging in multiple literacy practices, such as reading books, singing songs, and reciting poetry, is part of the daily life of many families. It is important to recognize that dual language learners have a variety of literacy experiences in their home language that range from an emphasis on oral language development to literacy activities involving print.
- Respect cultural values and behaviors reflected in the child's language and communication: Language and culture are highly integrated, so attention must be paid to cultural values and behaviors, which are embedded in both the language and communication style of the home language and the new language being learned.

Benefits of Maintaining Children's Home Languages

“All children benefit from the social and cognitive advantages of multilingualism and multiliteracy.” ^[112] Specific benefits include:

- Individuals who are multilingual switch between different language systems. Their brains are very active and flexible (Zelasko and Antunez, 2000).
- Multilingual people have an easier time understanding math concepts, developing strong thinking skills, using logic, focusing, remember, and making decisions, thinking about language, learning about languages
- Maintaining home languages supports children's maintenance of strong ties with their entire family, culture, and community.
- Multilingual children are also able to make new friends and create strong relationships in their second language—an important personal skill in our increasingly diverse society
- Children raised in multilingual households show better self-control (Kovács and Mehler, 2009), which is a key indicator of school success.
- People who use more than one language appear better at ignoring irrelevant information
- Thinking in a second language frees people from biases and limited thinking
- What is learned in a home language creates strong foundations that can be transferred when learning additional languages.
- Multilingual adults have more job opportunities around the world than monolingual adults and earn an average of \$7,000 more per year than their monolingual peers.
- Those that are multilingual can participate in the global community in more ways, gain information from more sources, and learn more about people from other cultures.

Multilingualism is an asset to individuals, families, and our entire society. Early childhood educators can share the benefits of bilingualism with families, find ways to support children's home languages, and encourage families to keep their language strong. It is important to “make sure families of emergent bilinguals understand the academic benefits and the significance of supporting their child's home language as English is introduced through the early childhood program, to ensure their children develop into fully bilingual and biliterate adults.” ^[113]

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5.5: Summary

The race, ethnicity, national origin, language, and other cultural considerations are important aspects of diversity for early childhood educators to be aware of. Partnering with families will allow you to learn about the unique cultures of the families you serve. Families that are immigrants, refugees, and asylees should be recognized for their strengths and may need support as they navigate unfamiliar systems to access resources. It is important that programs promote bicultural identities. The home language of dual language learning children should be recognized and valued. Teachers should make sure that families understand the value of multilingualism.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

6: Diverse Family Structures

Learning Objectives

- Explain the following laws within the Ideal Gas Law

[6.1: Introduction](#)

[6.2: Summary](#)

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6.1: Introduction

In this chapter, we will explore diverse family structures and terms that will help build a culture of inclusivity and equity. It is important to consider two overarching premises regarding family structures. The first is that Parents refers to biological, adoptive, and step-parents as well as primary caregivers, such as grandparents, other adult family members, and foster parents. The second is that Families can be biological or non-biological, chosen, or circumstantial. They are connected through cultures, languages, traditions, shared experiences, emotional commitment, and mutual support. ^[114] You may notice that we have used families, often even when referring to parent/caregiver throughout this book in an attempt to be as inclusive as possible.



Figure 9.1: This is a family. ^[115]

A feeling of belonging is critical to every child and family's well-being. The drive to form relationships with others begins in infancy and continues throughout early childhood. These relationships help children fulfill their potential in all areas of development—physical, social, emotional, and cognitive. Quality early childhood programs can expand children's experiences of forming relationships when the culture and core curriculum partners with families' and communities' central themes.

Many families have multiple identities and might include themselves in multiple family definitions. Most children see the caring adults who love and take care of them as their family and will refer to them in that way. It is important to recognize the complexity and variation amongst all families. It is recommended to connect with families to find out the language that they use to refer to their families to help respectfully answer questions that may arise. ^[116]

Understanding and conversations are important to gain insight into the structure of each family unit. It also assists in the individualization of the support offered to each child. Families come to an early childhood setting with distinct family structures and cultures that give meaning and direction to their lives. All families are complex and influenced by many factors: family traditions, countries of origin, geographic regions, ethnic identities, cultural groups, community norms, sexual orientation, gender identities, educational and other experiences, personal choices, and home languages.



Figure 9.2: Programs need to partner with all families. ^[117]

While every child and family are unique, many of our conversations with families involve common topics. We can anticipate that there will be discussions about learning and language, daily routines (such as sleeping, feeding, toileting), expectations, new skills, behavior, discipline, and relationships with peers and adults. We also know that each family will bring unique perspectives to these discussions. Ultimately, it is understanding the perspectives of families and seeing them as the experts on their children that helps create the best care and learning environment for their child. ^[118]

Below is a list of terms and definitions, many from the [Welcoming Schools organization](https://www.welcomingschools.org/) , intended to be a starting point for important conversations about family diversity. Many families have multiple identities and might include themselves in multiple family definitions.

- **ADOPTION:** When adults bring children into their families and legally become the parents of those children.
- **ADOPTIVE PARENTS:** The parents of children who have joined the family through adoption.

- **BIRTH PARENT:** A biological parent. People may also use the terms birth mother or birth father. Most often used in the context of adoption.
- **DONOR OR SURROGATE:** People who help other people have children.
- **BLENDED FAMILY:** Two families who come together to form a new family. This may include step-parents and step-siblings.
- **CHOSEN FAMILY:** People who you care about and consider family, such as friends or neighbors.
- **CONDITIONALLY SEPARATED FAMILY:** A family separated for a specific period of time; having a family member in jail, prison, a mental health care facility, the hospital, etc.
- **DIVORCE:** When people legally separate and end a marriage.
- **EXTENDED FAMILY:** All of your relatives, including your grandparents, aunts, uncles and cousins. In some families, this can include neighbors, friends and chosen family.
- **FOSTER PARENT:** People—other than a child's first family—who take children into their homes and take care of them for as long as their family needs help. Sometimes children will return to their first family, sometimes foster parents go on to become adoptive parents or permanent guardians and sometimes children will be adopted by other families.
- **GUARDIAN:** A person who has responsibility by law to care for a child; a person other than the biological parent who takes care of a child. The person may be biologically related to the child, such as a grandparent.
- **INTERFAITH FAMILY:** When people of different religious backgrounds are part of the same family. Some families choose to raise their children primarily in one faith, some choose to teach their children both faiths and others practice multiple faiths.
- **HALF-SISTER or HALF-BROTHER:** When siblings have one biological parent in common.
- **LGBTQ FAMILY:** A family in which some people are lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, non-binary or queer. This could include parents, guardians, foster parents, children, chosen family, siblings or grandparents who are LGBTQ.
- **LESBIAN:** Women who love women.
- **GAY:** People who love people of the same gender, typically men who love men.
- **BISEXUAL:** People who love people not exclusively of one particular gender.
- **PANSEXUAL:** People who love people regardless of their sex or gender.
- **TRANSGENDER:** When your gender identity (how you feel) is different than what doctors/midwives assigned to you when you were born (girl/boy or sex assigned at birth).
- **NON-BINARY:** People who do not feel like the words “girl” or “boy” fit. They may feel like both or neither. They sometimes use pronouns such as they, them, theirs.
- **QUEER:** People use this word as a way to identify with and celebrate people of all gender identities and all the ways people love each other. When used in a mean way, it is a word that hurts.
- **MIXED FAMILY:** When people of different racial and cultural backgrounds are part of the same family. People of different ethnic, religious or national backgrounds can also form families who are “mixed” in terms of culture, skin color, language and/or religious practices.
- **MULTIGENERATIONAL FAMILY:** When more than one generation of a family lives together.
- **MULTIRACIAL FAMILY:** When people of different racial backgrounds are part of the same family.
- **MULTILINGUAL FAMILY:** When people within a family speak more than one language.
- **SIBLING:** Children or adults who share a parent whether biologically or not.
- **SINGLE-PARENT FAMILY OR SOLO-PARENT FAMILY:** A family in which one parent cares for the child or children.
- **STEP-SIBLINGS:** If a divorced or solo parent forms a family with a new person and that person already has children, those children can become step-siblings to their children.
- **STEPPARENT:** When a divorced or solo parent forms a family with a new person, the new partner might become a stepparent to their children. ^[119]
- **TRANSNATIONAL FAMILY:** A family residing in two different countries.

What Programs Can Do

The family compositions represented in the populations served by early childhood programs are quite diverse. Staff members typically develop strategies for accommodating this diversity. Sometimes problems arise for staff members because the children and families they serve have not yet acclimated to the social changes this diversity represents. The problems can sometimes emerge in the interactions among the children who are puzzled by and react negatively to the differences or the stigmatizing comments

made by some parents about others. A situation in one program may be an example: Katie is overheard by staff members saying to Martin: “My mommy says I can’t play with you because you have two mommies living together at your house.” It is unclear whether Katie really understands what she is saying, but the situation represents a teachable moment for the children and the staff.

A series of books may be read in circle time that introduce children to different types of families and point out what is common to all (i.e., adoptive families, foster families, single-parent families, multigenerational families, and families led by a grandparent or a gay or lesbian couple). These families represent different ways that adults come together to take care of and love the children they have the responsibility to raise. For some families and staff members, this may represent a complex issue in which they are caught between creating a safe and supportive environment for children who have two mommies and respecting the concerns of parents

who, for religious or other reasons, promote a different view at home. In such cases, staff members may need to check with families and meet with them before circumventing what is said at home.

Two Mommies

This scenario involves an openly lesbian couple who enroll their child in an infant/toddler care program. It focuses on differences of beliefs and attitudes among staff members concerning the definition of a legitimate family unit. It opens up the thorny issue of a teacher judging a family as engaging in “wrong” or unacceptable behavior because that behavior contradicts the teacher’s personal beliefs. What do you think is the responsibility of a culturally responsive professional in such a situation?

The Scenario

For the first time, a family consisting of two female parents—both of whom are open about being lesbians—joins the infant/toddler care center. During the intake session, both women make it clear that they want to be acknowledged as the parents of the infant. They cross out “father” on the admission form and substitute “mother,” so that there is a place for each woman to write down her name. They also ask permission to contribute a poster that shows “two-mommy families” and a few picture books with images of two-mommy and two-daddy families.

The center director consents to their requests. However, when she informs the staff about the family, conflicting responses to having openly lesbian parents in the program necessitates a staff discussion. Christine, the teacher in whose room the infant will be placed, is uncomfortable with the situation. She tells other staff members that she thinks it is wrong to encourage homosexuality, since she believes it is a sin. She wants the director to tell the family that only one parent can be considered the infant’s mother, and that person is the only family member who should interact with the program. She also refuses to use the poster or picture books the family wants to contribute.

Marie, an assistant teacher, agrees with Christine. She even suggests that, to avoid problems, the director not admit the family into the program. She explains that since homosexuals cannot properly raise a child, she does not think the program should encourage homosexuality by accepting the infant.

Rachel explains that she has no problem with a two-mommy family, but she is worried that admitting this family into the program will cause problems with other families. In the interests of keeping the peace, she reluctantly supports Christine’s suggestion to identify only one person as the infant’s mother and that no materials show two-mommy families.

Carrie disagrees with the others. She takes the position that, as professionals, they have a responsibility to support all families equally and to make sure that all the infants and toddlers have their family visible in the program. She reminds her colleagues that the family composition and members’ roles within families vary widely. Carrie further explains that she is not questioning her colleagues’ personal beliefs, but argues that professionals need to act according to professional ethics and not just according to their personal beliefs.

Sarah agrees with Carrie. She reminds her colleagues of the following excerpt from the California Early Childhood Educator Competencies publication: “Cultural perspectives of children, families, staff, and colleagues vary widely on issues such as differences in individual children’s learning, strengths, and abilities; gender identity and gender-specific roles; family composition and member roles” (CDE 2011, 21).

Sarah reminds staff that there was a time when many people considered all single mothers to be immoral and bad parents. Sarah further states that it is equally prejudicial to automatically assume that all two-mommy families are “bad.” Carrie adds to Sarah’s point, declaring that child-rearing problems arise in families of all kinds of cultural backgrounds and configurations. ^[120]



Think About It...

How is this scenario about cultural responsiveness?

How do you feel each of the staff (Christine, Marie, Rachel, Sarah, and Carrie) on their cultural responsiveness? Why?

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6.2: Summary

Educators need to be prepared to serve the diverse array of families they will encounter across their careers. Many types of family structures have been introduced in this chapter. Programs should implement policies that acknowledge and respect different structures of families. And teachers can get to know families and ensure that all children's families are recognized and authentically included in the classroom.



Think About It...

What experiences do you have with diverse family structures? Do you have a reaction to any of these definitions? How might your experiences and feelings about diverse family structures affect how you care for children and interact with their families?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

7: The Influences of Stereotypes, Prejudice, and Discrimination

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Define what stereotypes are and how to dispel them.
- Articulate how hate can be unlearned.
- Describe and understand the role of culture.
- Explore how to find accurate information and gain essential knowledge of culture.
- Gain and understand the challenges created by poverty regardless of racial and ethnic background.
- Explore messages children see and hear in childcare settings.
- Practice culturally responsive care.
- Address cultural relevance in making curriculum choices and adaptations.

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[7.2: Thoughts Become Behaviors](#)

[7.3: Hate is Learned and Can Be "Unlearned"](#)

[7.4: Rights of the Child](#)

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7.1: Introduction

This chapter begins by describing the effects of stereotypes. Stereotypes lead to misinformation about others especially when we come from a place of judgement. We know that hate is learned. This means that hate can be unlearned. As we explore this topic, we will look at the importance of learning accurate information and gaining knowledge through developing reciprocal relationships with the families we serve. We will look at the importance of learning accurate information and gaining knowledge. The chapter places an emphasis on culture because early development and learning must be viewed within a cultural context and occurs through social contexts, as in families and communities, using language and everyday experiences (California Department of Education 2009a). Culture also “has an influence on the beliefs and behaviors of everyone.” As research shows “culture influences every aspect of human development and is reflected in childrearing beliefs and practices. (National Research Council and Institute of Medicine 2000, 3). ^[226]



Figure 15.1: Development and learning must be viewed within a cultural context ^[227]

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7.2: Thoughts Become Behaviors

What we know becomes what we feel. And what we feel affects our behavior. Let's look at how stereotypes can lead to discrimination.

Table 15.1: Definitions ^[228]

Term	Function	Definition
Stereotype	Cognitive; thoughts about people	Overgeneralized beliefs about people may lead to prejudice
Prejudice	Affective; feelings about people, both positive and negative	Feelings may influence treatment of others
Discrimination	Behavior; the treatment of others	Holding stereotypes and harboring prejudice may lead to excluding, avoiding, and biased treatment of group members

Stereotypes

Stereotypes are distorted pictures of reality that broadly label one group as being a certain way. Stereotypes influence our perception, evaluation, judgment, and memory about individuals and events. People tend to learn stereotypes from the people around them—such as peers and family—or from the media and entertainment. Overcoming stereotypes and working to eliminate bias are continuous processes.

It is essential to learn accurate information about different groups of people (e.g., race, religion, gender) through various ways (e.g., attending cultural events). However, this could reinforce stereotypes. Getting to know others who are different from us is very helpful in counteracting stereotypes, when we care about another person who has different experiences, we want to learn more about who they are which helps to dispel the stereotypes we have grown up with. It is important to remember that different does not mean abnormal or deficient.

To counter negative stereotypes, you can acknowledge you have a bias or stereotype, analyze what manifested it, and then seek out positive examples that cancel out or disprove the negative label. Doing this requires time, openness, and sensitivity. In stereotyping, assumptions are made about a person on the basis of his or her group membership without learning whether the individual fits those assumptions. To avoid stereotyping, we should reflect on our own beliefs about all aspects of child rearing and early childhood education. We must acknowledge our own beliefs and biases about specific groups of people that may be unintentionally communicated to children and families. ^[229]

Prejudice

Humans are very diverse and although we share many similarities, we also have many differences. The social groups we belong to help form our identities (Tajfel, 1974). These differences may be difficult for some people to reconcile, which may lead to prejudice toward people who are different. Prejudice is a negative attitude and feeling toward an individual based solely on one's membership in a particular social group (Allport, 1954; Brown, 2010). Prejudice is common against people who are members of an unfamiliar cultural group. Thus, certain types of education, contact, interactions, and building relationships with members of different cultural groups can reduce the tendency toward prejudice. In fact, simply imagining interacting with members of different cultural groups might affect prejudice. Prejudice often begins in the form of a stereotype. ^[230]

Discrimination

When people act on their prejudiced attitudes toward and stereotypes about a group of people, this behavior is known as discrimination. Discrimination is negative action toward an individual as a result of one's membership in a particular group (Allport, 1954; Dovidio & Gaertner, 2004). As a result of holding negative beliefs (stereotypes) and negative attitudes (prejudice) about a particular group, people often treat the target of prejudice poorly.

Different Forms for Discrimination: The –isms

Unfortunately there are many forms of discrimination. These are often referred to with the suffix –ism.

Racism

Racism is prejudice and discrimination against an individual based solely on one's membership in a specific racial group. Racism exists for many racial and ethnic groups. Black, Latinx, Jewish, Arab, Asian, and Native Americans all experience systemic discrimination in the United States. Most people do not show extreme racial bias or other prejudices on measures of their explicit attitudes (as these are conscious and controllable). However, measures of implicit attitudes (which are unconscious and uncontrollable) often show evidence of mild to strong racial bias or other prejudices.

Sexism

Sexism is prejudice and discrimination toward individuals based on their sex. Typically, sexism takes the form of men holding biases against women, but either sex can show sexism toward their own or their opposite sex. Like racism, sexism may be subtle and difficult to detect. Common forms of sexism in modern society include gender role expectations, such as expecting women to be the caretakers of the household. Sexism also includes people's expectations for how members of a gender group should behave. For example, women are expected to be friendly, passive, and nurturing, and when women behave in an unfriendly, assertive, or neglectful manner they often are disliked for violating their gender role (Rudman, 1998). ^[231]

Table 15.2 – Other –isms

Term	Definition
Ableism	Discrimination against persons with disabilities or in favor of those without ^[232]
Ageism	Prejudice and discrimination toward individuals based solely on their age ^[233]
Classism	Discrimination or prejudice that is based on social class. ^[234]
Cissexism	Bias or prejudice favoring cisgender people, people whose gender corresponds with their sex at birth (discrimination against transgender people) ^[235]
Heterosexism	Discrimination against homosexuals, bisexuals and asexuals in favor of heterosexuals. ^[236]
Religism	Prejudice based on religious affiliation. ^[237]
Weightism	Prejudice or discrimination based on body weight ^[238]

Homophobia

Another form of prejudice is homophobia: prejudice and discrimination of individuals based solely on their sexual orientation. Like ageism, homophobia is a widespread prejudice in U.S. society that is tolerated by many people (Herek & McLemore, 2013; Nosek, 2005). Negative feelings often result in discrimination, such as the exclusion of lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) people from social groups and the avoidance of LGBT neighbors and co-workers. ^[239]

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7.3: Hate is Learned and Can Be "Unlearned"

Prejudice and discrimination persist in society due to social learning and conformity to social norms of the dominant race, which is white. Children learn prejudiced attitudes and beliefs from society: their families, teachers, friends, the media, and other sources of socialization.

It is important to note that hate can begin at an early age. As professionals in the early care field we must work to educate and eradicate the negative ideas and behaviors that stem from it. No child is born with prejudice. They are born wanting to connect with others. Just as love is learned when children are cherished and nurtured, hate is learned by the messages that are both verbal and nonverbal. As hate is learned, so it can be unlearned. According to the Anti-Defamation League, leading experts on child development argue that the problem begins early. ^[240] Infants and toddlers are keen observers of difference and when those differences are not supported, it can lead to fear, which can lead to hate if not nurtured appropriately. By preschool age, children have already learned stereotypes or acquired negative attitudes toward "others." The process of countering those negatives with positives must also begin at an early age.

In an article by Caryl Stern, "Talking to Young Children about Bias and Prejudice," Stern states, "Louise Derman-Sparks, an expert in the field of early care and education, points to three major issues that are important to keep in mind when talking to children about prejudice and discrimination.

1. Children are not colorblind

It is a myth that young children don't notice people's differences, especially skin color. Children are in fact acutely aware of our shadings and gradations, and they need matter-of-fact, simple, and truthful explanations of these differences. At an early age they may ask for explanations. It is important for families to be equipped to respond.

2. Talking about differences does not increase prejudice in children

Being aware of differences is not the same as avoiding, ridiculing, or fearing specific differences. Moreover, awareness does not lead to negative attitudes. Children learn biases from important adults in their lives, from the media, from books and from peers. Families need to talk to their kids-to give them accurate information and to reinforce when their behaviors indicate a value of differences as opposed to a prejudice. Surprisingly, many adults have trouble opening up and broaching the subject. For these adults, it's a good idea to practice the discussion with an adult before taking it up with children. Above all, families should ensure their words of wisdom are in tune with their actions. Sending a contradictory message only reinforces prejudices and stereotypes.

3. It is not enough to talk about similarities among people

While we want our children to understand the things that bind us as human beings, it is equally important that they understand that shared characteristics, language and customs are expressed in different ways. When we continuously tell our children, "See, they do that just like us;" we may be implying that similarities are the only things that make "those" people acceptable.

4. Talking to Children About Diversity: Preschool Years

A child's age is one of the most important factors in considering how to begin a discussion on any subject dealing with prejudice, discrimination or, more simply, the things that make people different. The most important thing to keep in mind is that it is never too early, or too late, to talk to children about respecting diversity."

We must prepare ourselves to respond to acts of bias, even if they are unintentional. Children will carefully observe how the adults in their lives intervene when someone is the target of hurtful or discriminatory behavior. Silence in the face of injustice conveys the impression that adults condone the behavior or consider it not worthy of attention. We must make it clear to our children that name-calling will not be tolerated and explain the thinking behind "zero tolerance" when it comes to prejudice." ^[241]



Figure 15.2: Children use adults as models of how to respond to hurtful behavior. ^[242]

Learning Accurate Information

Learning accurate information about cultures different from your own requires persistence, dedication, openness, and honesty. Exploring your own values, beliefs, and traditions—and learning how they impact you and the way you engage with the world—are preliminary steps to be taken before understanding others. In taking such steps, you also become more aware of your own stereotypes, assumptions, and biases (Sue 1998). There are many ways to pursue a higher level of self-awareness and reflect on your experiences and the cultural lens through which you view the world.

Gaining Knowledge

Increasing your cultural knowledge is essential. Families are rich sources of information for learning about their cultures. It is important to engage in meaningful conversations with families. Key skills that are important to possess include the ability to listen to others who are culturally different, to actively learn about their experiences, and to respect differences in a nonjudgmental way (Derman Sparks 1995).



Figure 15.3: Knowledge is gained by listening to others that are culturally different. ^[243]

There are many ways to learn about different groups of people. Reading information about a cultural group is one way (Phillips 1995), inquiring and learning about the various home practices of families (Gonzalez Mena 1995) is yet another. It is equally important to seek out educational and multicultural training experiences (Derman Sparks 1995). In addition, learning how culture can be integrated into the curriculum and classroom environment is essential (Derman Sparks 1995). ^[244]

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7.4: Rights of the Child

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child applies to all children, whatever their race, religion or abilities; whatever they think or say, whatever type of family they come from. It doesn't matter where children live, what language they speak, what their families do, whether they are boys or girls, what their culture is, whether they have a disability or whether they are rich or poor. No child should be treated unfairly on any basis. (UNICEF 1990, 1)

On the surface, the need to bring up racism, classism, or sexism would seem to be incongruous in the same breath as talking about childcare for children. Yet, sadly, it is necessary. Prejudice, bias, and societal inequity enter the lives of children in a variety of ways. Whether based on race, culture, gender, economic class, or family structure, these attitudes and realities have a negative, hurtful effect on the quality of life and development.

Although the child's immediate and extended family provides the primary environment of socialization for children in their early years, bias, prejudice, and societal inequity come from outside of the family. The professionals who provide children and their families with a range of services (e.g., child care providers, medical staff, social workers) are one source of the messages that convey whose way of life matters more and whose matters less. Some of these messages are obvious, some are subtle, and ironically, many are unintended. Some negative messages come from the attitudes and behaviors of the professionals. Many come from structural dynamics of the organizations in which human service professionals, including early childhood educators, work. These negative messages may include unexamined policies, procedures, and beliefs that create advantages for some groups and disadvantages for other groups.

The cumulative effect of messages about who matters (more or less) gradually influences how children begin to understand and feel about themselves and others—even in the first year of life. The messages also impact their quality of life. An understanding of the various forms of bias, prejudice, and inequity and how they influence children is critical to counteract potential damage to healthy development. Understanding grows from awareness, the first step to practicing culturally responsive, non-biased care that nurtures all children and families. ^[245]



Figure 15.4: Even early messages influence how children feel about themselves and others. ^[246]

Ethical Responsibilities To Families

In their Code of Ethical Conduct and Statement of Commitment position statement, the National Association for the Education of Young Children shares the core values underscoring ethical behavior in the field of early childhood care and education. These are:

- “Appreciate childhood as a unique and valuable stage of the human life cycle
- Base our work on knowledge of how children develop and learn
- Appreciate and support the bond between the child and family
- Recognize that children are best understood and supported in the context of family, culture, community, and society
- Respect the dignity, worth, and uniqueness of each individual (child, family member, and colleague)
- Respect diversity in children, families, and colleagues

- Recognize that children and adults achieve their full potential in the context of relationships that are based on trust and respect”

They also detail the ethical responsibilities that early childhood educators have that affirm commitment to the core values. In the section that shares ethical responsibilities to families, the following are included:

- Welcome all family members and encourage their participation in the program
- “Respect the dignity and preferences of each family and make an effort to learn about its structure, culture, language, customs, and beliefs to ensure a culturally consistent environment for all children and families”
- Respect families’ childrearing values and involve them in making decisions for their children
- Make every effort to communicate effectively with families in a language they understand
- Use families input when planning and implementing the program

And in the statement of commitment portion of the position statement, two of the commitments that early childhood educators make include:

- “Respect and support families in their task of nurturing children
- Engage in an ongoing process of self-reflection, realizing that personal characteristics, biases, and beliefs have an impact on children and families.” ^[247]

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7.5: What Children See and Hear in Child Care Settings

Messages about who matters or does not matter—and who matters more—are significant pathways of bias and inequity. The visual and auditory environment of early childhood education programs communicate many of these kinds of messages. These matter because young children are just beginning to amass and process information about themselves and others. And this awareness starts very early. For example, as young as six months, infants begin to notice differences in skin color (Bronson and Merryman 2009; Katz 1976). Noticing, paying attention to, or being curious about differences and similarities in their environment is not a sign of emerging prejudice, but rather a characteristic of how all children learn.

Inaccurate and stereotypical images of people like themselves are one type of bias that young children may encounter in the early care program. Those images communicate misinformation about their own social identities, which damages their developing sense of self and family. They need accurate, authentic photographs, posters, and pictures of themselves and their families. To begin to develop positive attitudes toward people different from themselves, children also need accurate images about people different from themselves. They do not need misinformation from commercialized, stereotypical, or cartoon looking images of people. Visibility (or the lack thereof) is another powerful pathway of bias and inequity.

When children see images of people who look like them, they receive a positive message for their self-concept. However, seeing only images similar to them conveys a second, negative message: only people like you exist or are important. Conversely, young children who do not see images of people similar to them in the early care and learning environment receive the message that they do not matter as much as the people whose images and languages are visible. Experiencing invisibility in an early childhood education program is especially damaging, since it is one of the first societal institutions that very young children encounter.

The numerical balance of images that reflect diverse racial identities, families, and cultural ways of life also conveys messages about who matters and who matters more. When the majority of the images in an early childhood environment reflect the “way of life defined by the dominant group in society as the “normal or right way to live, the message conveyed is that the dominant group is the most important. When one cultural group’s way of life becomes the standard for everyone else, the seeds of racial and cultural advantage and disadvantage are sown.

In addition to the visual environment, the sounds of a program also convey information about whose family’s way of life matters or not. The language of the program is the most obvious source of sound—and it may or may not be what children hear at home. Hearing a language different from the one at home creates a more complicated adjustment and developmental challenges for young children than that experienced by those whose home language matches the program’s language. Similarly, the sounds of music and song evoke—or do not evoke—the security of home, depending on how similar or different they are from what a child is used to.

A growing body of research also indicates that misinformation and prejudice about social identity harm children’s development (e.g., Derman-Sparks and Ramsey 2004; Tatum 2003). The negative impact is cumulative—coming not just from messages of direct prejudice, but also from the effect of microaggressions, brief, everyday exchanges that send denigrating messages to certain individuals because of their group membership, ^[248] as well as messages of invisibility regarding who they are.

Children receive both overt messages and covert messages, those that are disguised and subtle and often rationalized in ways that lead to societal acceptance ^[249] in many forms. They also are exposed to prejudices and discriminatory actions in their daily lives. These all build up to become toxic to children’s sense of self, well-being, and competence. A non-biased environment is a necessary condition for nurturing each child’s healthy identity and positive attitudes about diversity. However, the visual and auditory environment is only one component of culturally responsive programs. ^[250]

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7.6: Socialization in Two Cultures

The widespread use of outside-the home group and family care signifies that, for the first time in human history, the family—nuclear and extended—is no longer the only primary child-rearing environment of young children. This means that in the earliest years, hundreds of thousands of children experience two differing cultural contexts every day—that of the family and that of early care and education. Thus, the cultural continuity, the consistency of cultural practices, in child rearing is disrupted.

Paying attention to cultural continuity and cultural discontinuity between home and early childhood education programs is a central issue in a culturally responsive approach. Where a child's experiences fall on the continuity-discontinuity continuum depends on the degree of similarity or difference between the specific cultural dynamics of their family and those of the early childhood program. These include fundamentals such as furniture, equipment, spatial organization, care procedures, language, and how staff members interact with the children and each other. Some children experience a high degree of continuity, while others experience a high degree of discontinuity. The more discontinuity children face, the more they find that what they are learning in their family about how to be in the world does not work for them in the care and education program.

Discontinuity between very young children's two primary socialization environments may have negative effects on children. The degree of familiarity or unfamiliarity with a program's care practices makes it easier or harder for children to adjust, to build strong relationships, to act and feel competent, and to feel secure. It is also known that a primary source of a child's sense of belonging, security, and empowerment in an early childhood education program comes from as much continuity as possible with what children experience in their home culture.



Figure 15.8: Continuity between the home culture and ECE program is important. ^[251]

Young children thrive when an early childhood program respects and integrates their home languages and cultures into all of its operations. In such programs, children can learn and develop because they feel “supported, nurtured, and connected not only to their home communities and families but also to teachers and the educational setting” (NAEYC 1995, 2). In sum, when a child's home culture (including language) differs significantly from the culture of her/his childcare program, she does not have the opportunity to thrive. ^[252]

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7.7: Summary

The stereotypes that people hold about others can lead to the development of prejudice. That prejudice can become discrimination that excludes others and leads to inequitable treatment. That discrimination includes, racism, sexism, ableism, ageism, classism, cissexism, heterosexism, religism, weightism, and homophobia. But prejudice is learned and thus can be unlearned. We can teach children accurate information about others.

We must also be aware of the impact that early education and care settings have on children and the way they see themselves and their families. For many children, this involves disruption of their cultural continuity. Educators must work to provide a caring community for children and their families.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

8: The History and Influence of Systemic, Internalized Privilege and Oppression

Learning Objectives

After this chapter, you should be able to:

- Differentiate privilege and power
- Provide examples of privilege
- Discuss the Privilege as Practice Framework
- Describe the Culturally Responsive Strength-Based Framework
- Define paradigm and discuss why the deficit-oriented paradigm of diversity needs to be shifted

[8.1: Introduction](#)

[8.2: Privilege as Practice Framework](#)

[8.3: The Journey Towards Equity](#)

[8.4: Practices for Engaging Difference, Privilege, and Power](#)

[8.5: The Culturally Responsive Lens](#)

[8.6: Creating a Paradigm Shift](#)

[8.7: Summary](#)

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8.1: Introduction

Everyone is unique. This simple and somewhat obvious statement has significant implications when we consider the challenges associated with working together, creating community, and collaborative decision-making.

Research on group dynamics has shown that greater degrees of difference in social settings correlate with increased resilience (Lozano, 2007) and even creativity (Simonton, 1999). Page (2007) has further shown that groups that display a diverse range of perspectives and approaches to problem solving usually significantly outperform groups of like-minded experts at solving challenging problems. ^[253]

This is extremely important to remember in the early childhood education field. We need multiple and differing opinions on children and how to problem solve any challenges that will occur within our time with children.



Think About It...

Could you imagine how care for children in early childhood environments might look if we never had different opinions or thought processes? What would it be like if there weren't multiple options for families to choose from in the curriculum and environment sense?

The same forms of difference that enhance resiliency, creativity, and ability to solve problems can also lead to significant social challenges and conflict. This is the contradiction of diversity. Throughout history, diversity has provided the raw material for evolution of language, philosophy, and social and material innovation. And at the same time, humans have often used difference (e.g., skin color, spiritual belief systems, sex, learning styles, political affiliation, sexual orientation, etc.) as a basis for oppression and violence. Human history and the present day offer countless examples of persecution on the basis of differences. This history and legacy of oppression has led to a pattern where many forms of difference are culturally isolated and oppressed. In the absence of authentic and reciprocal relationships across difference, we miss out on the potential creativity, adaptability, and resilience that diversity can bring. ^[254]

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8.2: Privilege as Practice Framework

There should be the goal of enhancing our collective ability to engage with difference to strengthen relationships and improve the health of the systems that we inhabit. The following framework outlines an analytical system and a form of practice that we are calling Privilege as Practice. The specific goals of this framework include:

- Deepening and expanding our capacity for self-awareness
- Furthering our ability to understand our own particular uniqueness to better understand how we each flourish and thrive
- Learning to recognize how systemic structures, norms, and processes preference certain differences over others
- Learning to identify degrees of privilege and recognize how multiple identities interact (intersectionality) in different social systems
- Building capacity to use our privilege and power to benefit the health and well-being of the systems that we inhabit
- Tending to the impacts of historical and present day forms of oppression and trauma

The Systemic Progression

As described throughout this book, diversity is a simple fact-of-life. Difference exists in all systems and has the capacity to be the raw material for adaptation, creativity, and resilience. Yet in many social systems, we find that accrued power is used to oppress, homogenize, and assimilate expressions of difference that do not fit with the dominant perspective or ideology. This pattern causes harm, limits the potential of individuals in the system, and consequently diminishes the wisdom and creativity of the group. Understanding the primary dynamics and processes associated with this pattern can be helpful in building our capacity to engage with difference with well-being in mind. Figure X.X below illustrates the common pattern and progression by which certain differences accrue power in social systems.

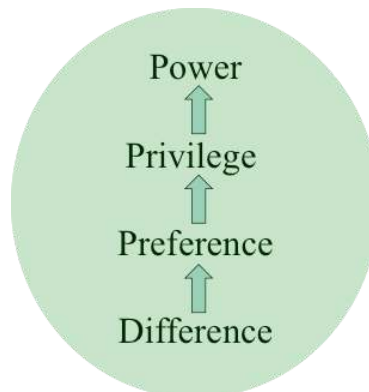


Figure 16.1: The green circle in this diagram represents any social system (an organization, community, school, family, etc.). The progression shown in the circle begins with difference and illustrates a common pattern by which power is accrued by individuals who embody certain characteristics. ^[255]

This progression can be used to track a variety of differences (internal, external, socially constructed, etc.) as they play out in a variety of different social systems across different scales. Like any conceptual framework, the patterns illuminated by this progression can be helpful in understanding power and privilege dynamics, and it is important to remember that this representation is a simplified interpretation of complex system dynamics. ^[256]

An example of systemic oppression and privilege can be found among young Black ^[257] * boys. The following describes information about how oppression and privilege have impacted the lives of children gathered by the Office of Head Start.



Figure 16.2: There are troubling education disparities for Black boys. ^[258]

Quality programming in early childhood programs incorporates knowledge of and respect for families' cultures and implementation of best practices including quality learning environments, intentional teaching, and family engagement strategies. When these program pieces are in place, they best support the development and learning of young children.

However, these program pieces are not always in place for ALL children. Evidence has been growing about the educational disparities facing Black boys. Many have not benefited from what is known about the connection between culturally responsive programming and child development. There have been reports on their disproportionately high suspension and expulsion rates from preschool. Educators and policy makers have made negative comments about the school readiness of young Black boys.

Awareness also has been growing about the societal context in which Black males live. News media and government reports have documented the gap between the realities of their daily lives and the American dream. The facts are stunning: in comparison to White Americans, Black males are more likely to live in poverty, live with only one parent, drop out of high school, and be unemployed (My Brothers Keeper Task Force, 2015). Taken together, these facts attest to the persistent challenges Black males face, starting at an early age.

“

Neither zip code nor skin tone should predetermine the quality of a child's opportunities; however, too many children from low-income families, and [Black] students in particular, are without access to high-quality early education, which can make them less likely to enter elementary school prepared for success.

— David J. Johns, Executive Director, White House Initiative on Educational Excellence for African Americans citing research findings (Ackerman & Barnett, 2007) ^[259]

The research has highlighted an educational opportunity gap. Human potential is realized when strengths are built on, and the job of early childhood education is to do just that. But for many children, their potential is not realized starting at an early age. And the problem is not with them; their potential is untapped because, in the words of many educators and policy makers, there is an “opportunity gap” (Duncan, 2014). Some say the opportunity gap develops as early as 9 months of age, especially for Black males

(Aratani, Wight, & Cooper, 2011 as cited in Iruka, 2013), and the gap is well-documented in the preschool years, when these disparities play out in the arena of school readiness.



The term opportunity gap refers to the well-documented disparities in educational opportunity associated with race, ethnicity, class, community wealth, and other factors.

— U.S. Department of Education, Office of Civil Rights Data Collection, 2014 ^[260]

The term “achievement gap” is widely used to refer to disparities in the educational performance of Black or other minority children. It is often cited in regard to test scores in reading and math for older children and in vocabulary knowledge for preschoolers. Often the reasons behind an achievement gap are erroneously cited to be inadequate home environments or children unable to learn basic skills who fall further and further behind. Such reasoning seems to “blame the victim,” and is based on deficit thinking. The term opportunity gap clearly places responsibility on those entities, such as early childhood and school settings that are responsible for providing equal learning opportunities.

Admittedly, there are many populations of children who experience an opportunity gap — often they are referred to in the aggregate as minority children or children of color. Along with increasing public awareness of the negative societal context affecting Black Americans, the project focus was triggered by reports on the disproportionate expulsion and suspension rates of preschool boys, and Black boys in particular.

- Black children were expelled from preschool at twice the rate of whites according to national data from 2005. Boys made up 91% of those expelled, and preschoolers were expelled at three times the rate of children in kindergarten through 12th grade (Gilliam, 2005).
- In 2011, national data indicated that Black children made up 18% of preschool enrollment, but 48% of preschool children were suspended more than once. Boys received more than three out of four out-of-school preschool suspensions (U.S. Department of Education, Office of Civil Rights, 2014).

To say the least, these data were shocking to the public, educators, and policy makers. When preschoolers are expelled or suspended, the consequences are great. They are missing out on learning opportunities that would prepare them for success in school. Also, their self-esteem and self-efficacy are compromised, which affects their learning.

What is behind these statistics? Research (Gilliam, 2005) identified factors that predicted child expulsion, including an extended school day and high teacher-child ratio. Specific classroom factors associated with high expulsion rates are:

- Teacher job stress as reported by staff, such as “This child’s classroom behaviors...
 - interfere with my ability to teach effectively.”
 - may result in someone getting hurt or property damage.”
 - are not likely to improve significantly.”
- Developmentally appropriate practices were infrequent
 - Daily use of worksheets and flashcards
 - Dramatic play once a month or never

The researcher concluded that teachers needed help managing challenging behaviors and that a mental health consultation intervention would be particularly promising and cost-effective.

Another perspective might be taken to interpret the challenging behaviors from a strength-based perspective — this would be in line with some of the current thinking about developmental research (Cabrera, 2013 a). It is also important that the field of early childhood education recognizes the importance of teachers to being deeply ingrained in understanding how children grow and develop and educated and trained to effectively guide children’s behaviors. One tool teachers can use is the Culturally Responsive Strength-Based (CRSB) Framework, described later in this chapter.

Several questions emerged from the research findings. When Black boys are enrolled in preschool, what are their experiences like? Are they of high quality? The answers were not very encouraging and helped explain the opportunity gap. Although positive

outcomes for children are rooted in respect for their culture and in implementation of developmentally appropriate practices, these elements are often missing or diminished in the preschool settings of Black boys (Barnett, Carolan, & Johns, 2013). ^[261]



Asa Hilliard, Black professor of educational psychology, framed the opportunity gap in a somewhat different way in his work (2003). “There is another gap [besides the achievement gap], one that is rarely acknowledged. It is a gap that has been submerged in the dialogue about intelligence and achievement because of the paradigm of human incapacity, especially pessimistic with respect to African students. This gap is the quality-of-service gap.” ^[262]



Think About It...

Can you think of other examples of privilege and oppression? If so, what are they? If not, what might that mean?

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8.3: The Journey Towards Equity

As mentioned previously in this book, becoming culturally responsive and equity-minded is not a simple or short journey. Hopefully, this book and the course you are using it for has given you information and opportunities to reflect on the important of early childhood educators engaging in this process with an open heart and open mind.

As you become aware of your own culture, the importance of forming strong partnerships with the families and authentic relationships with the children you serve, and recognize your role as an early childhood educator as advocate for social justice and equity, you can go even a bit deeper into your reflection on the importance of diversity and equity. This chapter introduces the process of reflecting on privilege and power and how those leads to oppression in our society and also how those with privilege and power can use those to make changes towards more equitable systems and environments across society (including early childhood education).

This process is rarely a comfortable or uncomplicated one. Our goal is not to assign blame or guilt, but to encourage respectful and thoughtful engagement and open-minded reflection that is appropriate for where you are at in your personal journey towards equity.

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8.4: Practices for Engaging Difference, Privilege, and Power

Understanding the pattern of why those in power continue to stay in power is critical to our ability to intervene and create something different. While there are many cases of intentional oppression and minimization of differences, there are also many situations where individuals in the mainstream group are unaware of their own privilege and are unconsciously supporting and reinforcing the status quo.

Part of the practice of engaging difference differently, involves honing our tracking and observational skills; learning to recognize the patterns associated with systems that minimize and oppress differences. In addition to improving our awareness and analysis skills, it is also critical that we develop skills, capacity, and courage to interrupt the dominant system archetype; using the privilege and power we have to find places in systems where we can leverage change to make the system healthier. This might involve changing our own behaviors, illuminating and influencing system dynamics, or tending to the impacts of marginalization and oppression.



Pin it! Privilege and Power

Privilege is a system of advantages, opportunities, and choices not available to all.

1. Privilege is contextual . We all move between sub-systems where we have different degrees of privilege (e.g., “at a social gathering my extroverted nature offers more privilege than when I’m in a silent retreat”).
2. Unearned privilege does not result from merit, integrity, or personal choice (e.g., “I have a suite of choices and advantages that are available to me because I was born as a White person in this country”).
3. Privilege rarely exists in a “have” or “have not” state. It is important to remember that we each have degrees of privilege.

Power is the capacity to exert influence or control in a system.

- Power can be accumulated from unearned privilege. It can also be earned – resulting from personal integrity (e.g., a person’s courageous actions can accrue respect and generate opportunities and influence).
- Power can be used to minimize and oppress difference (at individual, group and system levels) and create norms/structures that confer unearned privilege and power to a select few who embody certain characteristics. This is power over .

Power can also be used to create alliances and collaborations to change the ideology of oppression by transforming the norms and structures that would otherwise preference certain differences. This is power with. ^[263]

In many conversations about diversity, the terms power and privilege have taken on a negative connotation. And while power is often used to reinforce the status quo, minimize and oppress difference, and create norms/structures that confer unearned privilege and power to a select few, it can also be used to interrupt those cycles and create healthier systems.

As an example, we discovered the following story about a white woman who entered a popular women’s clothing store. After wandering around the store, she realized that all of the models in the big glossy photos on the walls were white. After some deliberation, she approached the store manager and pointed out this pattern and suggested that the photos be changed to include women of color. She said that she wouldn’t shop at a store that wasn’t making an effort to break the often unconscious patterns of white privilege. The store manager responded defensively, offering all of the reasons that the photos on the wall were out of her control. The customer pressed on, asking to file a formal complaint with the corporate headquarters. Upon leaving the store, the

customer was stopped by an employee of color who told the customer that she had been waiting years for a white person to finally point out that pattern and use her white privilege and power to make a change. She explained that as a woman of color, any critique that she might offer about the racial identities depicted in the photos could too easily be explained away by “oversensitivity” or a “chip-on-the-shoulder.”

This story of solidarity illustrates a different practice for engaging difference, privilege and power. Rather than using the unearned privilege and power associated with her whiteness to reinforce the status quo (or simply ignore the issue completely), the customer in this example used her power to attempt to interrupt the cycle of oppression. ^[264]



Think About It...

What might this process look like in early care environments?
How might early childhood professionals look closely at their environments to ensure that all are equitably represented?

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8.5: The Culturally Responsive Lens

You can also use the Culturally Responsive Strength-Based (CRSB) Framework, which is used by Head Start, to address diversity. This framework presents the big picture and identifies the program pieces that support the growth and development of all children.

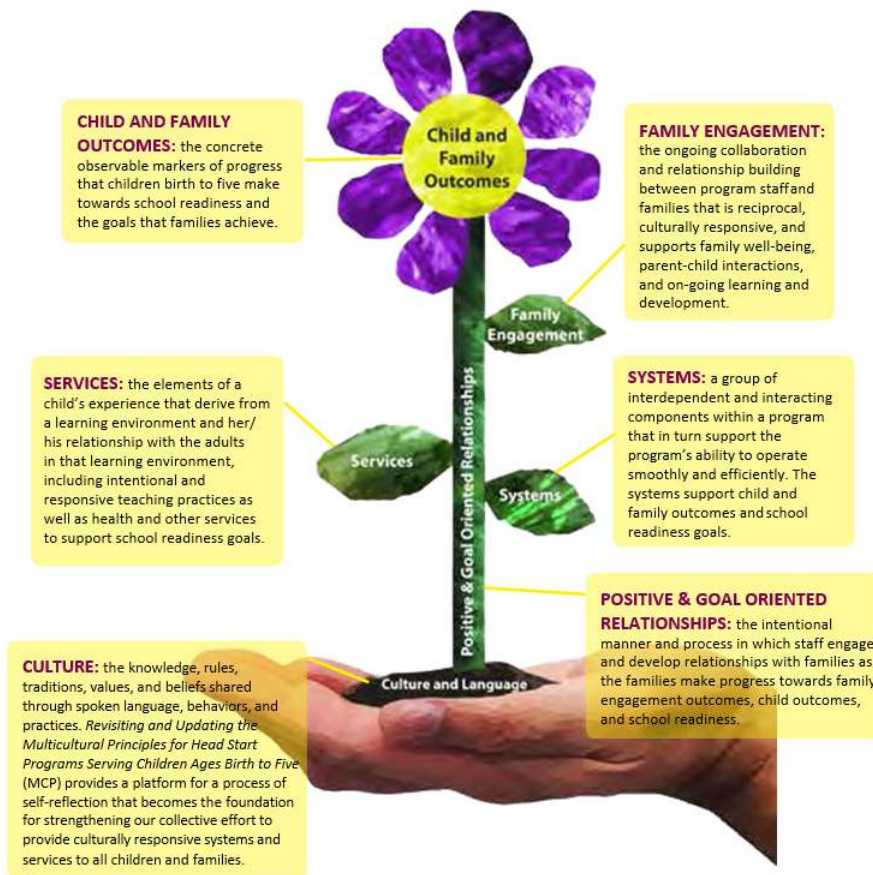


Figure 16.3: The elements of the CRSB Framework. ^[265]

Coupled with a culturally responsive approach, the CRSB Framework is a strength-based approach. The focus is on what children know and can do as opposed to what they cannot do or what they do not know. Cultural, family, and individual strengths are

emphasized, not just the negative and proposed interventions to “fix the problem” that resides with the children, their families, and/or their communities.



The strengths approach has a contagious quality and it intuitively makes sense to those who reflect a “cup half full” attitude in life.

— Hamilton & Zimmerman, 2012

If we ask people to look for deficits, they will usually find them, and their view of the situation will be colored by this. If we ask people to look for successes, they will usually find it, and their view of the situation will be colored by this. — Kral, 1989 (as cited in Hamilton & Zimmerman, 2012) ^[266]

The CRSB Framework should be used with the understanding that children are influenced by many environments, as represented in a bioecological systems model. A bioecological systems model captures the variety of environments that impact individual development over the course of a lifetime. Young children do not live in a vacuum, but co-exist in many environments that affect their development, starting with the family, extending into the community, and reaching out into the economic and political spheres.



Think About It...

There is also privilege surrounding socioeconomic status. How does the following excerpt change your perspective on future and current goals of children with different socioeconomic statuses? How will you as a teacher think about this?

A study done by Dumais (2005) found that:

- Parents from upper class backgrounds feel more comfortable in academic settings and feel education is an important part of their and their children’s lives.
- Parents in the lowest socio-economic status (SES) were most likely to believe that being able to count, draw, be calm, and know their letters before kindergarten are very important or essential
- More parents from the lowest SES (18%), than from the highest SES (7%), reported not being involved in their children’s schooling because they did not find anything interesting there
- 10% of parents from the lowest SES reported not feeling welcome at their child’s school, versus just 3% from the highest SES

56% of parents from the lowest SES expected their children will get a bachelor’s degree, while 95% of those from the highest SES expected the same ^[267]

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8.6: Creating a Paradigm Shift

A paradigm is the assumptions, concepts, values, and practices that influence how people view the world. Paradigms have been shaped over a lifetime by many influences that include families, schools, social and professional experiences, and the media. Each of us constructs our paradigms. Paradigms around diversity are often deficit-oriented, focusing on problems and vulnerabilities in the population being considered. These place emphasis on what people and families in that population are lacking.

Too often, children and their families in minority populations are considered “at risk” by policy makers, educators, and the media rather than “placed at risk” by a system that has historically viewed them from a deficit paradigm (Boykin, 2013). Scientific paradigms influence the ways that researchers in child development, often done by those in privilege and power, think and conduct their work. For example, research on minority children often employs a deficit perspective, and as a result, the knowledge base highlights the adversity and maladaptation of the minority children (Cabrera, 2013 a). Therefore, more is known about the problems than the positive qualities and strengths of the minority groups being studied. And this biased information leads many professionals to conclude that children from minority families are “at risk” and that they have many deficits to overcome in their learning and development.

But paradigms are not set in stone and for sure, the deficit-oriented paradigm needs to be turned on its head. A shift in mindset – a paradigm shift – is often experienced as a revolution or a transformation. It does not just happen, but rather it is driven by agents of change who might be families, community advocates, political leaders, researchers, educators, as well as other professionals. Ideas and activities in this resource also might trigger a paradigm shift in how you view those that are different from yourself.

As the research community shifts its deficit paradigm and redefines its research agenda, the knowledge base will expand to highlight successes and assets of children and their families. And this will lead high-quality program planning and implementation of effective strategies to promote all children’s learning and development. ^[268]

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8.7: Summary

Although research supports the value of diversity, it continues to be used to oppress those that are different. Individuals who possess qualities give preference by social values gain unearned privilege. This privilege can lead to power over those without privilege. Or it can be used to change the structure causing the oppression. The Privilege as a Practice And Culturally Responsive Strengths-Based Frameworks can both be used to create a paradigm shift in how we look at diversity and to mitigate oppression.

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